

Direct-to-Consumer Market and Go-To-Market Report

Ideal clients, market size, email delivery and the sales plan for GrowMailers

PREPARED FOR	Shardul Phuyal, GrowMailers
DATE	28 September 2026
VERSION	2.0 (final)
MARKETS COVERED	United States, United Kingdom, Canada, Australia, Ireland and New Zealand
CLASSIFICATION	Internal use only

Contents

About This Report.....	5
Purpose and scope.....	5
The two GrowMailers services.....	5
How to read this report.....	5
1. Types of Online Stores and Which Ones We Target.....	7
1.1 Types of online business and whether we can help.....	7
1.2 Why we skip dropshippers and print-on-demand.....	8
1.3 Quick decision checklist for qualifying a store.....	8
1.4 Tricky cases.....	8
2. Why Ad Costs Are Killing Profit (and How Email Fixes It).....	9
2.1 The size of the US online shopping market.....	9
2.2 Why ads keep getting more expensive.....	9
2.3 Import taxes (tariffs) and higher costs.....	9
2.4 The cost of getting a new customer vs. keeping one.....	10
2.5 Why getting customers back is so profitable.....	10
2.6 How to talk about this with clients.....	11
3. How to Read a Store's Tech Setup to Judge Fit.....	12
3.1 What tools DTC brands use.....	12
3.2 What each tool tells us.....	12
3.3 How to score a prospect.....	13
3.4 Always verify before reaching out.....	14
4. Who Our Perfect Clients Are.....	15
4.1 The entry requirements (must have all of these).....	15
4.2 Ascent client tiers (all technical repair jobs).....	15
4.3 Lhotse client tiers (monthly retainer).....	16
4.4 Why these four product types.....	16
4.5 Who to skip.....	17
4.6 What our perfect Lhotse client looks like.....	17
5. How Many Potential Clients Exist and Where They Are.....	19
5.1 The number of Shopify stores.....	19
5.2 Narrowing down to real prospects.....	19
5.3 Each country's role.....	20
5.4 Best US states to target.....	20
5.5 Watch out for fake US addresses.....	21
5.6 Time zone guide (working from Nepal).....	21
6. Who Makes the Buying Decision and What They Care About.....	22
6.1 How teams change as brands grow.....	22
6.2 The four types of decision-makers.....	22
6.3 How to handle common objections.....	23
7. How Much Money Each Type of Product Makes.....	24
7.1 What real company financials look like.....	24
7.2 Profit per order by product type.....	24
7.3 How profit builds over time.....	25
7.4 How many extra repeat orders our services need to generate.....	25
7.5 The levers that move the model.....	26

8. When to Sell (the Business Calendar)	27
8.1 The inventory money cycle	27
8.2 Month-by-month guide	27
8.3 When budgets reset by country	28
9. How to Measure Whether Email Is Working	29
9.1 How much revenue email should drive	29
9.2 Industry benchmarks by platform	29
9.3 The Apple problem (why open rates are broken)	29
9.4 Targets for a healthy Lhotse client	30
9.5 How to test whether email actually caused purchases (holdout tests)	30
10. Automated Emails vs. One-Off Campaigns	32
10.1 Automated sequences vs. campaign blasts	32
10.2 The customer journey and what emails go where	32
10.3 Specifications for each sequence	33
10.4 Campaign planning	34
10.5 Example: rebuilding email for a \$6M pet brand	34
11. Keeping the Email List Clean	36
11.1 How Klaviyo charges	36
11.2 How to categorize subscribers	36
11.3 Sunset sequence process	37
11.4 Bots and list bombing	37
12. Email Security Settings Explained Simply	39
12.1 How the three settings work together	39
12.2 SPF: who is allowed to send email for this domain	39
12.3 DKIM: proving the email is really from you	40
12.4 DMARC: tying it all together and setting a policy	40
12.5 What email providers now require	41
12.6 Klaviyo's sending setup	42
12.7 What is NOT a real finding	42
12.8 Ascent repair process: no disruption to sending	43
13. How to Test Whether Emails Actually Reach the Inbox	44
13.1 Where emails end up (industry data)	44
13.2 The measurement toolkit	44
13.3 How to use seed tests correctly	44
13.4 Shared IP vs. dedicated sending IP	45
13.5 Warm-up schedule for a new sending domain	45
13.6 How to handle delivery problems (incident runbook)	46
13.7 Validity's "Heatwave" blocklist	46
14. The Shopping Holiday Calendar	48
14.1 Key dates: October 2026 to November 2027	48
14.2 How big peak season was in 2025	49
14.3 Peak season email preparation checklist	50
15. When to Pitch Which Service	51
15.1 The master selling calendar	51
15.2 Planning backward from Black Friday 2027	52
15.3 How long each deal typically takes	52
15.4 Priority by market and time of year	53
16. Email Marketing Laws by Country	54
16.1 Rules that apply everywhere	54

16.2 United States: the basic rules.....	54
16.3 United Kingdom.....	55
16.4 Canada: strictest rules in our markets.....	55
16.5 Ireland, Australia, and New Zealand.....	56
16.6 Six-country comparison and pre-send checklist.....	56
16.7 GrowMailers' own outreach setup.....	57
16.8 Rules our Lhotse clients must follow.....	57
17. How to Find Clients, Audit Their Setup, and Close the Sale.....	59
17.1 The full pipeline.....	59
17.2 Step 1: Build the prospect list.....	59
17.3 Step 2: The 15-minute outside audit (no login needed).....	59
17.4 Step 3: Record a 90-second audit video.....	61
17.5 Step 4: Email templates.....	61
17.6 Step 5: Build a financial model on the discovery call.....	62
17.7 Step 6: The Ascent proposal.....	62
17.8 Step 7: Lhotse onboarding.....	63
Appendix A. Word List.....	64
Appendix B. Sources.....	66

About This Report

Summary: This report explains how direct-to-consumer (DTC) online brands make money, which of them are the best clients for GrowMailers, how many exist, how email delivery works, and when and how to sell to them. Every section opens with a short summary. The detail underneath is written for daily use by the team.

Purpose and scope

The report covers online brands that sell their own products mainly through their own website, with a focus on stores built on Shopify that send email through Klaviyo. It concentrates on four product types where customers buy again and again: beauty and skincare, health supplements, food and drink, and pet supplies.

All figures come from named public sources available in September 2026, such as the US Census Bureau, Store Leads and Klaviyo. Where GrowMailers has made its own calculation, the text says "our estimate".

The two GrowMailers services

The report refers to GrowMailers' two services by name throughout.

	Ascent	Lhotse
What it is	A one-time repair of a brand's email delivery	A monthly service that runs the brand's email and SMS program
Price	\$5,000 one time	\$3,000 to \$5,500 per month
Main work	Fix email security settings, move off shared sending domains, clean the list, remove fake sign-ups, repair inbox placement	Plan and send campaigns, build automated email sequences, design, copywriting, testing and reporting
Length	2 to 3 weeks of repair, plus up to 10 weeks of gradual ramp-up if a new sending address is needed	Ongoing, after 2 to 3 weeks of setup
Best-fit brand size	\$1M to \$50M+ in yearly revenue	\$3M to \$20M in yearly revenue
Sign of success	Emails pass security checks, spam complaints stay below 0.1%, fewer bounces, better inbox placement	Email earns a larger share of website revenue, and holdout tests confirm the extra sales

Lhotse package	Monthly price	Best-fit brand size	What is included
Lhotse Core	\$3,000 to \$3,500	\$3M to \$6M	All automated sequences, 2 to 3 targeted campaigns per week, list cleaning, monthly report
Lhotse Growth	\$3,500 to \$4,500	\$6M to \$12M	Core, plus a managed SMS program, regular testing, reorder reminders and quarterly lift tests
Lhotse Scale	\$4,500 to \$5,500	\$12M to \$20M	Growth, plus website conversion work, advanced segmentation, multi-country calendars and a weekly strategy call

How to read this report

Element	What it tells you
Summary box at the start of each section	The main point in a few sentences. Reading only these gives a ten-minute overview.
Numbered subsections	The detail, checklists and reference tables the team uses day to day
Grey note under a table	Where the numbers come from
"Our estimate"	A calculation made by GrowMailers rather than a published figure

Element	What it tells you
Appendix A	Plain-English meanings of every technical term and abbreviation

1. Types of Online Stores and Which Ones We Target

Summary: A direct-to-consumer (DTC) brand makes or owns its products and sells them mainly through its own website, so it owns the contact details of its customers. That ownership matters more than the brand's size: a \$30M Amazon seller is a worse prospect than a \$4M Shopify brand, because the Amazon seller cannot email most of its buyers. We also exclude dropshippers and print-on-demand stores, even though they technically have an email list, because they lack the profit margin, product quality and staying power to benefit from our work.

1.1 Types of online business and whether we can help

Business type	What it means	Can they email their customers?	Ascent fit	Lhotse fit
Direct-to-consumer brand (DTC)	Makes or owns its products; sells mainly through its own website	Yes, fully	Strong	Strong
Online-born brand (DNVB)	An online brand that controls everything from product design to delivery	Yes	Strong	Strong , if finances are healthy
Subscription brand	Most revenue is repeat deliveries, often set up through an app called ReCharge	Yes	Strong	Strong (great for reducing cancellations)
Multi-channel retailer	Has its own stores and website, and also sells through big retailers	Web buyers yes; in-store buyers partially	Strong (for large repair jobs)	Depends: measure only website revenue
Half Amazon, half own website	Sells a lot through both Amazon and its own site	Only their own-site buyers	Maybe	Maybe: own site must be big enough alone
Wholesale brand	Sells mainly to retailers, not directly to shoppers	Small own-site list	Only if own site makes \$1M+	Skip
Marketplace-only seller	Only sells through Amazon, Etsy or TikTok Shop	No. Amazon hides buyer emails.	Skip	Skip
Dropshipper	Has no stock; a supplier ships each order directly	Technically yes	Skip	Skip
Print-on-demand / creator merch	Products printed only when ordered (using apps like Printful)	Rarely their own list	Skip	Skip

The word "e-commerce" covers any online sale, from Amazon down to a one-person Shopify store. Only the rows marked Strong or Maybe are our market.

A 2026 ShipBob survey found how brands rank their main sales channel:

Main sales channel	Share of brands
Own website	65%
Amazon	20%
Wholesale or retail stores	12%

Source: ShipBob survey, 2026.

The same survey found that 86% of brands sell through more than one channel. For that reason, **always measure a potential client by their own website revenue only**. Amazon and wholesale sales never go through Klaviyo, so they do not count.

1.2 Why we skip dropshippers and print-on-demand

Email works best when customers run out of a product they love and trust the brand. Dropshipped generic products do not build that kind of loyalty. These businesses also fail our test for three further reasons.

Reason	Why it rules them out
Thin profit margin	They do not have enough margin to pay for our services
Short lifespan	They often close within months, and our work depends on a domain the brand keeps for years
Low-quality subscribers	Their lists hurt both results and the case studies we show future clients

They are easy to spot and skip. Printful and Printify are two of the top ten apps on US Shopify stores, and an app called Fourthwall is used by 7% of US Shopify stores that also have Klaviyo.

1.3 Quick decision checklist for qualifying a store

Work through the steps in order. Each answer either ends the check or sends the store to the next step.

Step	Question	If no	If yes
1	Is the brand's own website their main way to sell?	Go to Step 2	Go to Step 3
2	Does the website alone make \$1M+ (for Ascent) or \$3M+ (for Lhotse)?	SKIP (they sell mainly through Amazon or wholesalers)	Keep going to Step 3, but use only website revenue numbers
3	Do they make or own their products?	SKIP (dropshipper, print-on-demand, reseller)	Go to Step 4
4	Do they use Shopify or Shopify Plus?	HOLD (check back later)	Go to Step 5
5	Do they use Klaviyo for emails?	Omnisend: HOLD (never make them switch). Mailchimp: NURTURE (introduce our work).	Go to Step 6
6	Is it beauty, supplements, food or pets?	SECONDARY : pursue only if repeat buying is visible	QUALIFIED : score it (Section 3)

1.4 Tricky cases

Case	How to handle
A \$25M brand with 60% of sales on Amazon	Their website makes \$10M, which qualifies for Lhotse. Use only the website number, and expect email to cover a smaller share of revenue because Amazon buyers never joined the email list.
A brand with physical stores	A great Ascent candidate: more sending tools (such as a store POS system) mean more security gaps to fix. For Lhotse, check whether in-store buyers are added to Klaviyo at checkout.
A company that owns several brands	Each brand has its own email domain and list, so each one is a separate Ascent project. Pitch the whole group, but price each brand separately.
A brand where most revenue is subscriptions	Subscriptions do not count as "email revenue" in Klaviyo reporting, so email looks weaker than it really is. Judge by cancelled-subscription prevention and cross-selling instead.
A Shopify Plus store with a custom build	Website scanning tools might not detect their apps. Confirm by signing up for their email list and reading the technical headers in the email you receive (Section 17 explains how).

2. Why Ad Costs Are Killing Profit (and How Email Fixes It)

Summary: Online shopping keeps growing, but the cost of getting each new customer is growing faster than the profit that customer brings on their first order. At the current rate of ad price increases, the average clothing brand's first sale will lose money within two years. Email keeps customers coming back at almost no cost, and that is what GrowMailers sells.

2.1 The size of the US online shopping market

Measure	Figure	Note
US online shopping, Q2 2026	\$340.2 billion	US Census Bureau
Share of all US retail, Q2 2026	17.1%	US Census Bureau
Growth vs. the same quarter a year earlier	+12.2%	US Census Bureau
US online shopping, full year 2025	About \$1.23 trillion	
DTC brands' share of US online shopping	About 19% (roughly \$234 billion)	Expected to stay about the same through 2028

Source: US Census Bureau, Q2 2026.

DTC brands are those that cut out retailers and sell directly to shoppers. There is a catch in the growth figures: some of it comes from higher prices due to tariffs and inflation, not more units sold. Brands are making more dollars, but not necessarily more profit.

2.2 Why ads keep getting more expensive

Meta (Facebook and Instagram) reported a 12% rise in its average ad price in mid-2026, while the number of times an ad was shown went up 14%. If conversion rates stay the same, brands spend about 12% more to get each purchase. Google advertising works the same way: it is an auction, and prices keep going up.

The table shows what happens to a clothing brand's profit per first order if ad costs keep rising at 12% a year.

Year	Ad cost per purchase	Profit left from first order
Today	\$39.24	\$5.62
+1 year	\$43.95	\$0.91
+2 years	\$49.22	-\$4.36 (a loss)
+3 years	\$55.13	-\$10.27 (a bigger loss)

Our estimate, assuming prices and conversion rates stay the same.

This does not cause an immediate crisis. The first order simply earns a little less money each month until it quietly starts losing money. Brands that already earn profit from repeat customers can handle this, while brands that do not will find their growth plan stops working.

2.3 Import taxes (tariffs) and higher costs

Import rules changed several times in 2026. The US paused duty-free entry (where small packages below \$800 came in without taxes) and is ending it permanently on 1 July 2027.

Who is affected	Impact
Brands that make products overseas	Now pay higher import taxes
Brands in Canada, the UK and Australia shipping to US customers	Now face duties they did not pay before

Several DTC businesses closed in 2025 because of this combination of tariffs, inflation, higher ad costs and less investment money available.

2.4 The cost of getting a new customer vs. keeping one

There are two ways to measure ad spend per customer, and they give different answers.

Measure	How it is calculated	Notes
Cost per purchase	Ad spend divided by all purchases, new and returning together	This is what Triple Whale (an analytics tool) reports
Cost per new customer	Ad spend divided by <i>new</i> customers only	Always higher than cost per purchase

The worked example below shows how many sales a beauty brand needs to recover the cost of getting one new customer.

Step	Calculation	Result
Cost per new customer	1.5 × the \$33.44 cost per purchase	About \$50
Profit per sale	After product and shipping, before ads	About \$38.93
Sales needed to break even	\$50 ÷ \$38.93	About 1.3 sales

Product type	Sales needed to recover the cost of a new customer
Beauty, supplements, clothing	About 1.3 to 1.6
Food, pet	2.2 to 2.5

In every product type we target, the brand needs customers to come back.

2.5 Why getting customers back is so profitable

Getting customers back (called "retention") earns more money through three levers.

Lever	What it means
Repeat rate	What percentage of buyers come back at all
Frequency	How often they buy
Profit per repeat order	Bundles, upsells, and not giving away unnecessary discounts

The worked example below uses an \$8M beauty brand that gets 50,000 new customers a year.

Step	Calculation	Result
Raise the 12-month repeat rate	25% to 30% of 50,000 new customers	2,500 more returning customers
Extra repeat orders	2,500 customers × 1.4 orders each	3,500 orders
Extra profit	3,500 orders × about \$39 profit per order	Roughly \$136,000 per year
Compare with Lhotse	Extra profit vs. the annual cost of Lhotse	2 to 4 times the cost

That is a large return from a single improvement.

2.6 How to talk about this with clients

Talking point	How to use it
Talk about profit, not email open rates	"Orders you don't pay Facebook for" is what founders and finance people care about.
Compare Lhotse to buying the same orders through ads	At a \$40 average ad cost per purchase, 150 extra repeat orders a month would cost \$6,000 in ad spend. Lhotse is the same price.
Do not use made-up statistics	The popular claim that "customer acquisition costs rose 60% in five years" comes from a 2022 vendor blog post with no real data behind it. Smart buyers know this.

3. How to Read a Store's Tech Setup to Judge Fit

Summary: The apps a brand uses on its website tell us its size, budget and likely problems before we ever talk to it. Shopify plus Klaviyo is the minimum requirement, and paid growth tools like Attentive or Northbeam signal a larger brand with a real retention budget. We use these signals to give each prospect two scores: a **Lhotse Fit Score** (how good a Lhotse client they would be) and an **Ascent Urgency Score** (how badly their email delivery needs fixing).

3.1 What tools DTC brands use

Category	Tools
Storefront	Shopify; Shopify Plus (\$2,300–2,500/month)
Email and SMS	Klaviyo; Postscript; Attentive; Omnisend
Subscriptions	ReCharge (handles repeat delivery orders)
Analytics	Triple Whale; Northbeam (ad tracking tools)
Customer service	Gorgias (support chat and tickets); Okendo or Yotpo (reviews)
Fulfillment	3PL warehouse partner (84% of brands use one)

Every tool that sends emails on the brand's behalf (support, reviews, subscriptions) is another one we need to check in an Ascent audit.

3.2 What each tool tells us

Tool	Share of US Shopify stores using it	What it signals	What we say in our pitch
Shopify Plus	2.5%	Strong signal of a bigger brand (fees alone cost \$27,600+/yr, so almost always a \$1M+ brand)	Good fit for both services
Klaviyo	14.5%	Required: this is the gate	Both
Attentive	0.58%	Large, enterprise-level brand with a big SMS budget	Ascent; Lhotse Scale
Northbeam	0.11%	Large ad budget and a team that cares about measurement	Lead with real lift results
Postscript	1.7%	Running SMS; has a retention budget	Lhotse Growth
ReCharge	2.1%	Repeat-purchase model is already running	Focus on reducing cancellations and cross-selling
Triple Whale	1.3%	Tracks all marketing spend carefully	Frame results as "lower blended marketing cost"
Gorgias	1.0%	Has a customer service team sending from the brand domain	Check email security settings on support emails
Mailchimp	5.8%	Rarely a serious email program	Nurture gently
Omnisend alone	2.2%	Often a deliberate choice	Hold; never push them to switch platforms
Printful / Printify / Fourthwall	Top-10 apps	Print-on-demand	Skip

Source: Store Leads, 1,179,951 live US Shopify stores, September 2026.

Three platform facts shape how we pitch:

1. **Klaviyo is growing fast.** Revenue grew 26% in mid-2026, and brands paying Klaviyo more than \$50,000/year grew 36%. Bigger brands are investing heavily in email.
2. **Shopify rewrites the email sender** when a brand has no security record (DMARC) set up. The email shows up to customers as being from "shopifyemail.com" instead of the brand's domain. This is a clear sign the brand needs Ascent.
3. **Owners love Klaviyo's power but hate the bill.** GrowMailers sells the expertise to make Klaviyo worth paying for. We never push them to switch.

3.3 How to score a prospect

Lhotse Fit Score (out of 100)

This score measures how good a Lhotse client the prospect would be. It adds five components and subtracts penalties.

Component	Points available
Platform	0 to 20
Size	0 to 30
Tools they use	0 to 20
Product type	0 to 15
Email program gaps	0 to 15
Penalties	Subtracted from the total

Gate: if they do not use Klaviyo, the score is 0 (hold or nurture).

What we measure	Criteria	Points
Platform	Shopify Plus	20
Platform	Regular Shopify above \$250k/month in sales	12
Platform	Regular Shopify below \$250k/month	0
Size (estimated monthly sales)	\$420k–\$1.0M/month (\$5M–\$12M/year)	30
Size	\$1.0M–\$1.67M/month (\$12M–\$20M/year)	25
Size	\$250k–\$420k/month (\$3M–\$5M/year)	20
Size	Above \$1.67M/month	10
Size	Below \$250k/month	5
Tools used (max 20)	Postscript or Attentive +6; ReCharge +6; Triple Whale or Northbeam +5; Gorgias +3; reviews or loyalty app +3	Up to 20
Product type	Beauty, supplements, food or pets / clothing with repeat buying / other	15 / 8 / 3
Email gaps (max 15, from audit)	Only one welcome email or none +5; blasting full list more than 4x/week +4; no browse-abandonment email +3; no post-purchase or reorder reminder +3	Up to 15
Deductions	Registered business agent address –20; hired an email agency in the last 6 months –10; dropshipper or print-on-demand: skip	Varies

Ascent Urgency Score (out of 100)

This score measures how badly the prospect's email delivery needs fixing.

What we measure	Criteria	Points
Security setting gaps (max 40)	No DMARC record 20; two or broken DMARC records 20; emails show "via klaviyomail.com" above 5,000 subscribers 20; Shopify is rewriting their email sender 15; SPF record is broken 10	Up to 40
How exposed they are (max 30)	List above 50,000 10; using SMS heavily with frequent sends 10; in UK, Canada or Australia where Microsoft is big 5; Black Friday within 12 weeks 5	Up to 30
Visible signs of problems (max 30)	Test emails land in spam at 2+ email providers 15; order confirmation emails land in spam 10; no one-click unsubscribe button 10; welcome email arrives more than 1 hour late 5	Up to 30

Priority guide

Combine the two scores to decide what to pitch first.

Lhotse Fit Score	Ascent Urgency: Low (under 40)	Ascent Urgency: High (40+)
High (60+)	Lhotse first: lead with program gaps and upside	Ascent first, then Lhotse: fix delivery, then pitch the retainer
Low (under 60)	Nurture or skip: check back in 3 months	Ascent only: for \$1M to \$3M or \$20M+ brands

3.4 Always verify before reaching out

Tech databases can be wrong and can miss some setups. A wrong signal leads to a wrong pitch, so confirm these points by hand before reaching out to any prospect.

Check	How to confirm
Klaviyo is live	Sign up for their list and check the email you receive
Emails actually arrive	Confirm the signup email reaches your inbox
Growth tools are visible on the site	Look for a ReCharge membership portal or a Gorgias chat widget

Australia has the highest rate of Klaviyo use among the six countries we target: 23.6% of its Shopify stores use Klaviyo, compared to 14.5% in the US. Australian and UK brands tend to be more experienced, so lead with delivery depth and measurement rather than basics.

4. Who Our Perfect Clients Are

Summary: Our ideal client is a Shopify or Shopify Plus brand that uses Klaviyo, owns its products, and sells mainly through its own website in beauty, supplements, food, or pets. **Lhotse** targets brands making \$3M to \$20M per year, where email earns \$600k to \$6M per year and a \$36k to \$66k annual retainer makes more sense than hiring a \$70k to \$100k+ employee. **Ascent** targets brands making \$1M to \$50M+, including large brands with in-house teams who need a specialist repair job.

4.1 The entry requirements (must have all of these)

Requirement	What it means	How we check
Uses Shopify or Shopify Plus	Their online store runs on Shopify	Store Leads database; look at the website source code
Uses Klaviyo for emails	Their email platform is Klaviyo	Sign up for their email list; check the email headers
Owns their email list	Their own website is their main sales channel	Look at the site; Amazon is not the primary "buy" button
Owns their products	Makes or sells branded products (not drop-shipped generics)	No dropshipping apps on their store; branded product pages
Minimum revenue	\$1M+/year for Ascent, or the product-type minimum for Lhotse (Section 4.3)	Store Leads estimated monthly sales
Location	US, UK, Canada, Australia, Ireland, or New Zealand, confirmed as their real base	Check their address, phone, founder's LinkedIn, and shipping origin
Legal contact	We have a legal way to reach a decision-maker	Record where we found the contact

4.2 Ascent client tiers (all technical repair jobs)

	A1: Small brand	A2: Growing brand	A3: Large brand
Annual revenue	\$1M–\$3M	\$3M–\$20M	\$20M–\$50M+
Estimated monthly sales	\$83k–\$250k	\$250k–\$1.67M	\$1.67M–\$4.2M+
Typical team size	3–10 people	8–40 people	40–80+ people
Active Klaviyo subscribers	10k–40k	40k–250k	250k–1M+
Emails sent per month	50k–250k	250k–1.5M	1.5M–8M+
Who signs the contract	Founder	Founder (under \$5M); Head of Marketing above	CMO or VP; finance reviews
Common reason for calling	Shopify is rewriting their sender; shared Klaviyo domain; fake subscribers; rising bill	Emails landing in Microsoft spam; sudden bounce spike; worried about Black Friday	Moving to a new sending domain; enforcing security settings; recovering from an incident
How we pitch it	"Fix the foundation once, for under 0.5% of revenue"	"Protect the channel that earns you \$1M+ a year"	"A specialist repair your team can hand off, no disruption to sending"

4.3 Lhotse client tiers (monthly retainer)

	L1: Entry	L2: Core (sweet spot)	L3: Scale
Annual revenue	\$3M–\$5M	\$5M–\$12M	\$12M–\$20M
Email revenue (at 20–30%)	\$600k–\$1.5M	\$1.0M–\$3.6M	\$2.4M–\$6.0M
Suggested price	Core (\$3,000–\$3,500)	Growth (\$3,500–\$4,500)	Scale (\$4,500–\$5,500)
Retainer as share of email revenue	2.4–7%	1.2–5.4%	0.9–2.8%
Who makes the decision	Founder	Head of Marketing or Head of Growth	CMO or VP of Marketing; a retention person influences the decision
What they do instead today	A freelancer, or the founder doing it themselves	About to hire their first email specialist	Has an in-house team but also uses an agency
How we pitch it	"A full retention team for less than one hire"	"Stop hiring for skills you need part-time"	"Strategy, delivery, and testing your team doesn't have time for"

Brands outside the Lhotse range

Brand size	Why Lhotse does not fit	What to sell
Below \$3M	Lhotse would take 12–22% of a \$1.5M brand's email revenue, which is too much	Sell Ascent and revisit later
Above \$20M	These brands usually have in-house retention teams	Ascent is the right entry point

Revenue floors by product type

Product type	Minimum revenue for Lhotse	Reason
Beauty and skincare	\$3M	About \$39 profit per repeat order
Health supplements	\$3M	High margins and a 30-day reorder cycle
Pet supplies	\$4M	Only about \$22 profit per repeat order
Food and drink	\$5M	Only about \$17 profit per repeat order

Source: profit data in Section 7.

A food or pet brand with unusually large orders (above about \$90 average) or a strong subscription base can qualify at \$3M.

4.4 Why these four product types

US Klaviyo users are more concentrated in these categories than the average Shopify store.

Category	Share of US Klaviyo stores	Share of all US Shopify stores
Beauty and fitness	12.8%	10.9%
Food and drink	8.8%	7.1%
Health	7.3%	4.4%

The key is that customers **run out of the product and buy again**. This repeat buying is what makes email so valuable.

Product type	Typical time between reorders	Best automated email sequences	Watch out for
--------------	-------------------------------	--------------------------------	---------------

Reorder timing is a planning estimate. Always replace it with the brand's own average days between orders.

Clothing is the largest category on Shopify (29.1% of US stores) and is a secondary target. It qualifies when repeat buying is visible, for example in basics, uniforms, or restockable essentials.

4.5 Who to skip

Why we skip them	How to spot them	What to do
Marketplace-only or mainly Amazon	No real checkout on their own site; "Buy on Amazon" is the main button	Skip
Dropshipper	DSers, Zendrop, AutoDS, or CJdropshipping apps; 2–4 week shipping; generic products	Skip
Print-on-demand or creator merch	Printful, Printify, Fourthwall, or Spring	Skip
Does not own the customer relationship	Resellers, affiliates, or white-label stores	Skip
No email tool, or basic Mailchimp with no automation	No welcome email after signup	Nurture
Registered-agent address	Address matches a known business agent; founder is actually based abroad	Verify, then re-tag or skip
Too small	Estimated sales under \$83k/month, or under the product-type floor	Nurture; rescore in 3 months
\$50M+ with their own in-house team	CRM job postings; large marketing team	Ascent repair only
Canada or UK brand with only a personal Gmail address	Contact data shows a Gmail	Do not cold email
Hired an email agency in the last 6 months	Agency credited in emails or posts	Nurture; revisit in 9–12 months

4.6 What our perfect Lhotse client looks like

This is an example, not a real brand.

Attribute	Example brand
Business	\$7M health supplement brand, Austin, Texas
Platform	Shopify Plus
Own-website share of revenue	85%
Team	18 staff; three-person marketing team led by a Head of Growth
Tools	Klaviyo, Postscript, ReCharge, Triple Whale, Gorgias
Email list	95,000 people; only about 35,000 clicked or bought in the last six months
Welcome sequence	Only two emails long
Reorder reminder	None, even though 60% of revenue comes from 30-day products
Email share of website revenue	14%

This brand scores about 85 on the Lhotse Fit Score and 35 on the Ascent Urgency Score, so we lead with Lhotse. In the first three months, we would:

1. Build reorder and post-purchase email sequences.
2. Move campaigns to engaged-only segments.
3. Remove about 40,000 inactive people from the list, cutting their Klaviyo bill.

4. Set up a holdout test so the Head of Growth can show the founder real, proven numbers, not just platform estimates.

5. How Many Potential Clients Exist and Where They Are

Summary: The usable pool of potential clients, anchored on Shopify Plus brands, is roughly **4,500 brands across six countries**, about two-thirds of them in the US. At our midpoint monthly fee, that pool is worth about \$230M per year in possible revenue, and GrowMails only needs to win well under 1% of it. The limit is our own delivery capacity, not the size of the market. Some cities also show thousands of Shopify stores because overseas founders register their businesses there; these are not real local brands and must be filtered out.

5.1 The number of Shopify stores

Country	All Shopify stores	Shopify Plus stores	Stores using Klaviyo	Online share of all retail
United States	1,179,951	28,965	203,080	About 16.4%
United Kingdom	231,312	6,311	43,546	27.5%
Canada	147,721	3,812	22,584	7.5%
Australia	138,276	3,725	35,621	24%
New Zealand	26,522	581	5,322	Not available
Ireland	12,873	502	2,786	5.7%
Total	1,736,655	43,896	312,939	

Source: Store Leads data, 18 September 2026.

5.2 Narrowing down to real prospects

How we get from all Plus stores to real prospects

Step	Calculation	Result
Shopify Plus stores across six countries	Starting count	43,896
Distinct Shopify Plus businesses	÷ 1.5 (some owners have multiple domains)	≈ 29,263
Plus brands that use Klaviyo	× 60% using Klaviyo (planning estimate)	≈ 17,558
Brands in our target product types	× 30% in beauty, supplements, food, or pets	≈ 5,268
Real prospect pool	× 85% after removing dropshippers and similar	≈ 4,478 brands

Prospect pool by country

Country	Shopify Plus brands	Using Klaviyo	In target product types	Real prospect pool	Share
United States	19,310	11,586	3,476	2,955	66%
United Kingdom	4,207	2,524	757	643	14%
Canada	2,541	1,525	458	389	9%
Australia	2,483	1,490	447	380	8%
New Zealand	387	232	70	60	1%
Ireland	335	201	60	51	1%
Total	29,263	17,558	5,268	4,478	100%

These are estimates. Australia's real number is probably higher.

Important: This only counts Shopify Plus stores. Many smaller brands (\$1M to \$5M) use regular Shopify and are not counted here, so the real pool is larger.

Validation step: Use GrowMails' paid Store Leads account to export real counts by country, filtered to Klaviyo and our categories, in specific revenue ranges. Replace these estimates with real data.

Market size

Level	What it includes	Number of brands	Annual value
Total market	All Plus brands on Klaviyo, any product type	≈ 17,558	≈ \$895M
Reachable market	Our four product types	≈ 4,478	≈ \$228M retainer value + ≈ \$22M one-time Ascent
Target in 12–24 months	12–20 Lhotse clients and 30–50 Ascent projects per year	42–70	≈ \$760k–\$1.27M/year (0.3–0.5% of reachable market)

Delivery capacity limits us, not demand.

5.3 Each country's role

Country	Role	Key cities	Email risk	Special notes
United States	Primary, year-round (~2,955 brands)	California, New York, Florida, Texas, New Jersey, Utah	Gmail is dominant (54.4%)	Most lenient B2B email laws
United Kingdom	Secondary; best in Q1 (~643)	London (52,471 stores)	Microsoft is 32.3% of inboxes	Always test Microsoft delivery in every audit
Australia	Secondary; best Jan–Mar and Jul–Aug (~380)	New South Wales, Victoria	Microsoft is 30.2% of inboxes	Most experienced Klaviyo market; lead with depth
Canada	Selective (~389)	Ontario (44.7%), Quebec (19.5%)	Microsoft is 27.9%	Strictest email marketing laws (CASL); Quebec needs French
Ireland	Add-on to UK (~51)	Dublin	Microsoft-heavy (estimated)	Company email addresses only, not personal Gmail
New Zealand	Add-on to Australia (~60)	Auckland (11,232 stores)	No public data	13% of stores are food brands

5.4 Best US states to target

State	Shopify stores with 10–49 staff	Klaviyo usage	Notes
California	3,407	16.6%	Largest cluster; beauty and wellness
New York	1,730	Not tracked	Fashion and beauty density
Florida	1,134	14.8%	Many stores, but few are big enough; filter tightly
Texas	983	13.6%	Same as Florida
New Jersey	469	Not tracked	Consumer goods and beauty
Utah	411	18.8%	Highest Klaviyo rate measured; supplements cluster
Illinois	398	13.5%	Food and consumer goods
Colorado	380	15.3%	Outdoor, pet, natural products

In Florida, Texas, and Georgia, only 1% to 1.5% of stores have 10+ staff, compared with 3% to 3.8% in California and New York. Use stricter revenue filters in those states.

5.5 Watch out for fake US addresses

The town of Sheridan, Wyoming (population under 20,000) has 20,043 Shopify stores, the third highest of any US city. This is not a real DTC boom. Founders outside the US set up an American business using a registered agent, and that agent's address becomes the store's listed address. The same thing happens in Cheyenne, Wyoming; Delaware; New Mexico; and at shared office addresses in London.

How to filter these out

1. Flag any address that matches a known registered-agent location.
2. Check for a local phone number, a real returns address, and confirmed shipping origin.
3. Find where the founder actually works, using LinkedIn or the About page.
4. If they are actually based outside our six countries, skip them. If they are inside, update their country tag and apply that country's laws.
5. Log the check in your CRM.

5.6 Time zone guide (working from Nepal)

The GrowMails team works in Nepal Standard Time (NPT), which is 5 hours and 45 minutes ahead of London/UTC.

Market	Their business hours in Nepal time	Best approach
UK and Ireland	1:45 PM to 9:45 PM	Best overlap for calls; schedule for their afternoon
Australia (Sydney)	4:45 AM to 12:45 PM	Call Australian afternoons during Nepal mornings
New Zealand (Auckland)	2:45 AM to 10:45 AM	Nepal mornings; schedule emails
US and Canada Eastern	6:45 PM to 2:45 AM	Evening call shift; schedule emails
US and Canada Pacific	9:45 PM to 5:45 AM	Late calls; schedule emails

Schedule every outreach email to arrive at 8 to 10 AM in the recipient's time zone.

6. Who Makes the Buying Decision and What They Care About

Summary: For brands under \$5M, the founder signs everything. From \$5M to \$20M, a marketing leader signs and a retention specialist influences them; above \$20M, finance also reviews the contract. Founders care about cash and profit, growth leaders care about lowering their blended marketing cost, and retention staff want relief from heavy workload and risk. Lhotse competes directly with a new hire at the point where a brand would normally consider its first email specialist, usually between \$3M and \$8M in revenue.

6.1 How teams change as brands grow

Revenue	Marketing team	Spend on outside agencies	Who runs email	Who signs contracts
\$1M–\$3M	2–3 people	About 5% of revenue	Founder or freelancer	Founder
\$3M–\$8M	4–6, including an email person	About 7%	First email hire	Founder
\$8M–\$20M	7–12	About 7%	Retention specialist	VP Marketing, CMO, or Head of Growth
\$20M–\$50M	15–25, led by a VP or CMO	About 5%	Head of Retention + team	CMO or VP; finance reviews

Between about \$3M and \$15M, brands shift from needing "a Klaviyo specialist" to needing "a retention strategist." Many have someone who can build an email sequence but no one who can design a full retention strategy. Lhotse fills exactly that gap.

As brands get bigger, they also spend a smaller share of revenue on marketing. Brands under \$5M spend 30% to 45% of revenue on marketing, while ten public consumer brands spend a median of 13.3%. Smaller brands feel every dollar, so for small clients (L1) we sell Lhotse as a money-saver, not just a growth driver.

Typical org charts and where we fit

Brand size	Leader	Team structure	Who handles email	Where GrowMailers fits
\$3M brand	Founder/CEO	Operations, a generalist marketer, customer service	Founder or freelancer	Lhotse L1
\$10M brand	Founder/CEO	Head of Growth (paid media, email/retention, creative); finance; customer service	Email/retention person under the Head of Growth	Lhotse L2 , competing with the email/retention hire
\$30M brand	CEO	CMO over a Head of Retention (email manager, SMS manager, CRM analyst) and a Paid Media VP	Head of Retention and team	Ascent A3

6.2 The four types of decision-makers

	Founder / CEO	Head of Marketing / Growth	CMO	Retention Specialist
Responsible for	Cash, profit, strategy	Growing revenue per marketing dollar	Brand, growth, team	Email sequences, campaigns, list health, delivery

	Founder / CEO	Head of Marketing / Growth	CMO	Retention Specialist
What they measure	Cash, contribution margin, marketing efficiency	Marketing efficiency, new customer revenue, ad cost per customer	Growth, lifetime value vs. acquisition cost, team productivity	Flow revenue, email share, spam and bounce rates
Biggest fear	Paying an agency that overpromises	Missing revenue targets as ad costs rise	A public failure during Black Friday or peak season	Being blamed for a deliverability incident; burning out
What they need to hear	"Here's the cost, the payback, and how you'll know if it's working."	"Owned-channel revenue lowers your blended marketing cost."	"Specialist depth, measured by real lift tests, no risk to peak season."	"We take the heavy lifting and fix what you haven't had time for."
Evidence they trust	A model built with their own numbers	Holdout-tested lift results	Case studies at their revenue level	Technical audit findings and a clear process
Best starting offer	Ascent A1 or Lhotse Core	Lhotse Growth	Ascent A3, then Lhotse Scale	Ascent, positioned as their ally, not their replacement
What kills the deal	Vague promises; long lock-in contracts	Vanity metrics like "open rates"	A junior team; no risk management plan	Anything that makes them feel threatened

6.3 How to handle common objections

Objection	What they really mean	Our response	Evidence we offer
"We already have an agency."	Inertia, or quiet dissatisfaction	"No need to switch. Ascent is a technical repair job most agencies don't do. Here's what we found in your email headers."	The external audit results
"We'll just hire someone."	They think a hire is cheaper	"A good hire costs \$85k to \$135k fully loaded and has one skill set. Lhotse is \$36k to \$66k and brings a whole team."	Glassdoor salary data (Appendix B)
"Our open rates are fine."	Open rates are inflated by Apple auto-opens	"Apple auto-opens most emails without anyone reading them. Let's look at clicks and actual orders placed."	Section 9 benchmarks
"Klaviyo says delivery is fine."	Averages hide problems at specific providers	"About a third of UK, Canadian, and Australian inboxes are Microsoft. Let's check by provider."	Provider-level check
"Not right now. It's Black Friday prep."	A real freeze; do not push	"Completely understood. No retainer now. Here are two quick safe fixes; let's book a January conversation."	Section 15 safe-fix list
"Too expensive."	ROI is not clear yet, or cash is tight	"At your margins, Lhotse needs about 80 to 140 extra repeat orders a month. You already do 6,000."	Section 7 breakeven math
"An agency already disappointed us."	Past over-promising	"What did they measure? We report lift tested against a control group, not platform credits."	Sample holdout test report
"Isn't not having DMARC enforcement a failure?"	A scare tactic from past vendors	"No. A monitoring-only DMARC record meets every major email provider's rules. Moving to enforcement is best practice, done carefully, not urgently."	Section 12

7. How Much Money Each Type of Product Makes

Summary: For every product type we target, the first sale through ads barely breaks even or loses money, and profit starts with the second order. Beauty and supplements have the best margins, so Lhotse pays for itself fastest there, while food and pet earn less per sale and need a higher revenue minimum. Brands that automatically put a discount in every repeat-order email "out of habit" can wipe out a third of their profit per sale. Managing discounts is part of what Lhotse does.

7.1 What real company financials look like

Company	Revenue	Gross profit rate	Marketing spend	Net profit
FIGS (US clothing, 2025)	\$631M	66.5%	14.8% of revenue	5.4% net
Hims & Hers (US health, 2025)	\$2.3B	74%	39% of revenue	5.5% net
Temple & Webster (AU home goods, 2026)	A\$665M	30.2%	15.2% of revenue	3.3% operating profit

Even at large scale with strong gross margins, DTC brands make only about 5% net profit. The ones that survive are built on repeat customers. At Temple & Webster, 62% of orders in their latest year came from repeat customers.

7.2 Profit per order by product type

Planning inputs

Product type	Average order size	Gross margin	Shipping and payment fees	Average ad cost per purchase
Clothing	\$103.37	60%	15%	\$39.24
Beauty	\$68.29	72%	15%	\$33.44
Supplements	\$71.26	72%	14%	\$44.81
Food and drink	\$69.87	45%	20%	\$28.96
Pet	\$69.95	50%	18%	\$32.68

Resulting profit per order

Product type	Profit on first order	Profit on repeat order
Clothing	\$7.27	\$46.51
Beauty	\$5.49	\$38.93
Supplements	-\$3.48 (a loss)	\$41.33
Food and drink	-\$11.49 (a loss)	\$17.47
Pet	-\$10.29 (a loss)	\$22.39

Order sizes and ad costs are from Triple Whale's real customer data, US DTC brands, mid-2026. Margins and fee rates are our planning estimates; replace them with each brand's real numbers during a discovery call.

7.3 How profit builds over time

Profit accumulated per customer

Product type	After 1st order	After 3rd order
Clothing	\$7	\$100
Beauty	\$5	\$83
Supplements	-\$3 (loss)	\$79
Pet	-\$10 (loss)	\$34
Food and drink	-\$11 (loss)	\$23

Profit at 12 and 24 months

Product type	Expected orders in 12 months	Total profit at 12 months	Expected orders in 24 months	Total profit at 24 months
Clothing	1.4	\$25.87	1.7	\$39.83
Beauty	1.6	\$28.85	2.1	\$48.31
Supplements	2.2	\$46.12	3.0	\$79.18
Food and drink	2.0	\$5.98	2.8	\$19.96
Pet	2.3	\$18.82	3.3	\$41.21

Expected order counts are planning estimates. Use each brand's real data when available.

Supplements has the best economics. Even though the first order loses money, the 30-day reorder cycle quickly turns it positive. Food makes very little per sale at every stage, which is why it needs frequency and bigger basket sizes to work.

7.4 How many extra repeat orders our services need to generate

The break-even point is the service fee divided by the profit on one repeat order. For example, Lhotse at \$3,000 per month for a clothing brand needs $\$3,000 \div \46.51 , or about 65 extra orders per month.

Product type	Profit per repeat order	To pay for Lhotse at \$3,000/mo	To pay for Lhotse at \$5,500/mo	To pay for Ascent (\$5,000 once)
Clothing	\$46.51	65 extra orders/month	119 extra orders/month	108 extra orders total
Beauty	\$38.93	78	142	129
Supplements	\$41.33	73	134	121
Food and drink	\$17.47	172	315	287
Pet	\$22.39	134	246	224

In perspective

Brand	Orders per month	Extra orders Lhotse must generate	Share of monthly orders
\$5M beauty brand	About 6,100	78–142	1.3–2.3%
\$5M food brand	About 5,960	172–315	2.9–5.3%

For a beauty brand the target is modest. For a food brand it is harder to hit, which is why food brands need higher revenue before we take them on, and why we always use holdout tests to prove the numbers in low-margin product types.

7.5 The levers that move the model

What changes	The change	Effect on a beauty brand
More customers come back	Repeat rate goes from 25% to 30%	About 20% more repeat orders
Bigger repeat orders	Average order value rises 10% through bundles	Profit per repeat order goes from \$38.93 to about \$43.85
Faster reorders	Reminder email sent at day 38 instead of day 45 for a 40-day product	Catches buyers before they switch to a competitor
Unnecessary discounts	20% off every repeat order	Profit per order falls from \$38.93 to \$25.27, a 35% drop

Many brands automatically put a 15% to 20% discount code in every email out of habit. On a \$68 beauty order, 20% off takes away \$13.66 of revenue while the product cost and shipping stay the same.

Save discounts for win-back campaigns, first-order conversion and Black Friday, and use education and reviews everywhere else. This can add more profit than building any new email sequence.

In sales conversations: Rebuild this model live on every discovery call using the prospect's real numbers. When their own spreadsheet shows that Lhotse only needs 1% to 3% of their monthly orders to be incremental, the "too expensive" objection usually goes away.

8. When to Sell (the Business Calendar)

Summary: Brands pay for their holiday-season stock in summer, so they are most cash-strapped in August and September and have the most cash available in January and February. This cycle, more than any marketing calendar, decides when a founder will sign a retainer contract. Sell Lhotse when budgets reset and cash returns, and sell Ascent's quick, low-risk fixes when pressure is high. Never pitch a new retainer in the weeks before Black Friday.

8.1 The inventory money cycle

Timing	What happens	Cash position	Sales implication
May–Jun	Brand predicts Q4 demand	Planning	
June	Brand orders products	Commitment made	
Late June	30% deposit paid to factory	Cash going out fast	Worst time to ask for a retainer
September	70% balance paid when stock ships	Cash going out fast	Worst time to ask for a retainer
Oct–Nov	Stock arrives at warehouse	Cash still tied up	
December	Revenue peaks	Cash coming in	Best time to pitch begins
January	Returns land	Cash coming in	Best time to pitch

This cash timing gives Ascent a useful argument in the fall: *every order lost to the spam folder is inventory you have already paid for and cannot afford to lose now.*

8.2 Month-by-month guide

Month	Cash and inventory	What brands are focused on	Pitch window	What GrowMailers does
January	Returns arriving; new budgets just opened	Reviewing what peak taught them; resolutions (supplements surge)	★★★★★	Best window. Pitch Lhotse using their peak data. Pitch Ascent to brands that had December problems.
February	Recovering financially	Valentine's Day; Mothering Sunday prep (UK/Ireland)	★★★★★	Lhotse starts
March	Stable	Mothering Sunday (7 Mar); Easter preparation	★★★★★	Lhotse for US, Canada, non-gifting brands; Ascent everywhere
April	Stable; UK tax year starts	Building toward Mother's Day	★★★★★	Both services; Australian brands start planning EOFY
May	Forecasting Q4 inventory needs	Mother's Day (9 May); Australian EOFY prep	★★★	Australian brands must be ready by early May
June	Putting down Q4 deposits	Father's Day; Australian EOFY sales	★★★★★	Second window: pitch Black Friday readiness
July	Getting tighter; stock in transit	Amazon Prime Day; back-to-school	★★★★★	Lhotse starts still have time to be peak-ready; Ascent domain projects
August	Tight; stock on ships	Black Friday planning and audits start	★★★	Ascent first; last chance for Lhotse to be fully ready for peak
September	Worst cash moment	Final creative and list preparation for peak	★★	Last call; new sending domains must start warming by mid-September
October	Stock arriving; setup locks	Amazon Prime Big Deal Days; volume ramp-up	★	Safe Ascent fixes only until about October 16

Month	Cash and inventory	What brands are focused on	Pitch window	What GrowMailers does
November	Change freeze	Black Friday and Cyber Monday	☆	No pitching. Book January conversations.
December	Peak revenue arriving	Shipping cut-offs; Boxing Day	☆	Book January. December struggles feed January pitches.

8.3 When budgets reset by country

Country	Budget or financial year	What it means for timing
US and Canada	Mostly January to December	January is the best buying moment
UK and Ireland	Some brands reset budgets in April	Expect some budgets to open in April
Australia	July to June (EOFY = End of Financial Year)	Two good windows: January–March, and July–August after EOFY
New Zealand	Often April to March	Expect budgets to reset in April

Reading the signals in a brand's emails

What we observe in their emails	What it signals	What we do
Heavy discounting in August and September emails	Too much stock or a cash squeeze	Lead with Ascent or profit protection; delay the Lhotse pitch
Pre-orders or "ships in 6 weeks" messages	Cash tied up in inventory	Low-commitment, value-first approach
Product launches and new job postings	Growth mode	Lhotse, framed as scaling what already works
Fundraising announcement	New budget and pressure to grow fast	Lhotse Scale with board-ready reporting
Founder posting about tariffs or ad costs	Profit pressure is top of mind	Lead with retention economics (Sections 2 and 7)

9. How to Measure Whether Email Is Working

Summary: Open rates are no longer a useful measurement, because Apple automatically opens most emails whether or not a real person reads them. Judge an email program by click rate, purchase rate, revenue per email sent and, most importantly, holdout-tested lift (testing whether email actually caused the purchase or the customer would have bought anyway). Healthy brands earn 20% to 30% of their website revenue from email and texts. Below 8%, there is basically no real email program.

9.1 How much revenue email should drive

Email's share of website revenue	What it means	What GrowMailers recommends
Under 8%	No real program	Full Lhotse build, start with automated sequences
8–20%	Underdeveloped	Lhotse: fill sequence gaps and improve targeting
20–30%	Healthy	Lhotse: optimize and test
30–40%	Top tier	Ascent to protect it; Lhotse Scale if the team is stretched
Above 40%	Check the attribution settings	Often caused by a very wide attribution window, heavy discounting, or low ad spend

Always record which attribution window was used. By default, Klaviyo credits any order placed within 5 days of an email open or click as an "email order." This overstates email's real effect, especially since Apple auto-opens inflate the open count.

9.2 Industry benchmarks by platform

Metric	Klaviyo campaigns	Klaviyo automated sequences	Omnisend campaigns	Omnisend automated
Click rate	1.69%	5.58%	0.74%	4.66%
Order rate	0.97–1.34%	1.62–2.17%	0.08%	1.49%

Klaviyo 2026 data; Omnisend 2025 data. Compare a brand only against its own platform's numbers.

Rule of thumb: On Klaviyo, if a campaign's order rate is well below 1%, the email program has a problem.

9.3 The Apple problem (why open rates are broken)

Apple's Mail Privacy Protection (MPP) automatically pre-loads emails when they arrive. This registers an "open" in the email platform even if the person never reads the email. Litmus reported that Apple accounted for 62% of all tracked opens in July 2026, with MPP affecting about 55% to 60% of all opens.

Problem	Why it happens
Engagement targeting goes wrong	A filter for "opened in the last 90 days" now includes people who never looked at the email.
Subject line tests become unreliable	When machines open half your emails, open rate cannot be trusted as a test metric.
Inactive subscribers look active	The sunset policy (removing inactive people) fails because Apple keeps triggering "opens" even for dead subscribers.

The fix: define engagement by clicks, website visits and orders, not opens. Exclude Apple auto-opens where Klaviyo allows it. Only use opens as a sign of a technical problem at one specific email provider.

Which metrics to trust

Rank	Metric	What it tells you
1 (most trustworthy)	Incremental revenue	Lift tested against a control group (the real number)
2	Revenue per email	Reach × relevance × conversion
3	Order rate	Whether the email produced actual purchases
4	Click rate	Whether a real person engaged
5	Delivery health	Bounces, spam complaints, inbox rate by provider
6 (least trustworthy)	Open rate	Diagnostic only (broken by Apple auto-opens)

9.4 Targets for a healthy Lhotse client

Metric	Healthy range	When to act
Campaign click rate (Klaviyo)	1.5–2%+	Below 1% for 4 weeks in a row
Campaign order rate (Klaviyo)	About 1% or better	Well below 1%
Spam complaint rate	Below 0.05%	Above 0.05% (Klaviyo flags it); above 0.1% (Gmail's limit) means act now
Bounce rate	Below 1%	Above 2% (Klaviyo flags it)
Campaign frequency	2–5 per week; up to daily during Black Friday week	Only with engagement-based targeting

9.5 How to test whether email actually caused purchases (holdout tests)

A holdout test randomly holds back 10% of people from receiving a sequence, then compares how often that 10% buys against the 90% who got the emails. The difference shows how many purchases were genuinely caused by the email.

Running a holdout test

Step	What to do	Detail
1	Add a random split at the start of an automated sequence	90% get the emails, 10% get nothing (use 80/20 for smaller brands)
2	Measure orders from both groups	Use the same time period for both (for example, 14 days)
3	Run long enough	At least 4 weeks, and until the 10% group has at least 100 orders
4	Calculate incremental (real) orders	(Rate for emailed group – rate for control group) × number who got emails
5	Report both numbers	Platform-attributed and real incremental, side by side

Worked example

Step	Calculation	Result
Group sizes	90% emailed, 10% control	18,000 emailed; 2,000 control
Emailed group purchase rate (14 days)	720 orders ÷ 18,000	4.0%
Control group purchase rate (14 days)	56 orders ÷ 2,000	2.8%
Real incremental orders	1.2 percentage points × 18,000	216 real orders
Real incremental revenue	216 × \$68 per order	\$14,688 per month
Platform-attributed revenue	720 × \$68 per order	\$48,960 per month

Step	Calculation	Result
Share that is real	$\$14,688 \div \$48,960$	About 30%

In this example, about 30% of the revenue Klaviyo "credits" to email is real. That is still a strong result. A client who hears the honest number from GrowMailers first will trust every number we report after that.

Monthly scorecard for Lhotse clients

Area	What we report
Revenue	Email's share of website revenue (with attribution window noted); automated vs. campaign revenue split; revenue per email
Proof of value	Holdout lift vs. our fees
Engagement	Click and order rates by segment
Delivery	Gmail spam rate; bounce rate; security pass rate
List health	Net list growth; people removed
Cost	Current Klaviyo subscription tier

10. Automated Emails vs. One-Off Campaigns

Summary: Automated email sequences (triggered by customer behavior) earn far more per email than one-off campaign blasts. Klaviyo's own data shows automated sequences generate about 41% of email revenue from only 5% of emails sent, at nearly 18 times the revenue per email. Campaigns still drive most email revenue overall. A complete email program needs both: a solid base of automated sequences, plus targeted, well-planned campaigns on top.

10.1 Automated sequences vs. campaign blasts

	Automated sequences (triggered by behavior)	Campaign blasts (sent to a group at one time)
Share of emails sent	About 2–5%	About 95%
Share of email revenue	About 30–41%	About 60–70%
Revenue per email (Omnisend data)	\$2.87	\$0.18
Share of revenue from new buyers	About 48%	About 16%
Effect on delivery	Good (goes to people who want it)	Risky if sent to everyone

Nearly half of automated sequence revenue comes from new buyers. The best brands send fewer campaigns to smaller, more engaged segments, and use the time saved to improve their automated sequences.

10.2 The customer journey and what emails go where

Customer stage	Emails at this stage
Visitor	Browse, cart and checkout abandonment
Subscriber	Welcome sequence
First buyer	Post-purchase; review request
Repeat buyer	Reorder reminder
VIP customer	VIP perks; early access
Lost customer	Win-back
No response to win-back	Sunset, then removed from list

Cart abandonment and welcome sequences produced 76% of all automated orders on Omnisend in 2025.

Build order for a brand starting from scratch

Priority	Sequence	Note
1	Abandoned checkout and cart	
2	Welcome sequence	
3	Browse abandonment	
4	Post-purchase and review request	
5	Back-in-stock	
6	Reorder reminder	Most important for our four product types
7	Win-back	
8	VIP, birthday, and sunset	

10.3 Specifications for each sequence

Sequence	What triggers it	Emails and timing	What they say	Discount policy
Welcome	Signs up; exits when they buy	4–5 emails: immediately, day 1–2, day 3–4, day 6–7, day 10–12	Brand story, best sellers, proof, education, founder note	First-order offer in email 1 with an expiry reminder; no stacking discounts
Abandoned checkout	Started checkout, no purchase; 7-day re-entry block	3 emails (+1 SMS if consent given): 1–4 hours, 24 hours, 48–72 hours	Cart contents, reassurance, answers to objections	Offer in last email only, for first-time buyers only
Abandoned cart	Added to cart, did not start checkout	2 emails: 2–4 hours, 24 hours	Product and reviews	None
Browse abandonment	Viewed a product while identified; capped at 1 per 7–14 days	2 emails: 2–6 hours, 24–48 hours	Viewed item, alternatives	None
Post-purchase	Order placed or shipped; split first-time vs. returning	3–5 emails over about 30 days	Thank you, how to use it, review request at 10–21 days after delivery, cross-sell at 21–30 days	Loyalty or referral program, not discounts
Reorder reminder	Days since purchasing a used-up product; exits if reorder happens	2–3 emails starting about 7 days before they run out	"Running low?", one-click reorder, subscribe-and-save option	Subscription discount only
Back-in-stock	Customer requested an alert; stock crosses a threshold	1–2 emails (+SMS) when restocked	It's back; limited quantity	None
Win-back	No order in 1.5–2× the brand's average days between orders	3 emails over 2–3 weeks	What's new, best sellers	Staged: nothing, then soft hint, then a real offer last
VIP	Top 5–10% by total spend, or 3rd order	Welcome to VIP, then monthly perks	Early access, exclusive products	Access, not discounts
Sunset	No click, visit, or order in 120–180 days	1–2 emails over 7–10 days	"Still want to hear from us?"	Optional

Top-converting sequences

Sequence	Conversion rate	Revenue per email
Back-in-stock	6.72%	\$9.14
Welcome	2.11%	\$6.16
Abandoned cart	1.72%	\$3.59

Source: Omnisend, 2025 data.

Special cases

Customer type	How to handle them
Subscription customers	Skip the reorder reminder and win-back flows. They get their own journey with charge reminders and options to skip or swap.
Gift orders	Send a "treat yourself" cross-sell instead of a reorder reminder
Canadian cart abandoners	Email only with consent or an existing relationship (Canadian anti-spam law)

10.4 Campaign planning

Element	Standard practice
Frequency	2–5 per week normally; up to daily during Black Friday week, for engaged segments only
Segments	Engaged (clicked, visited, or ordered in 30 days); warm (31–90 days); cool (91–180 days); older goes to sunset
Who gets what	Engaged get everything; warm get 1–2 per week; cool get the strongest monthly send
Content balance	About 40% products and new arrivals, 30% education and brand story, 20% social proof, 10% offers (outside peak)
Testing	One variable at a time, measured by clicks and orders, never open rates

The best documented example of this working is Patrick Ta Beauty's Black Friday 2024. They sent nearly 6 times their usual email volume, but to properly segmented audiences. Their unsubscribe rate fell 37%, and email drove 30% of online revenue, up from 10% the year before (Klaviyo case study).

Text message (SMS) layering

Topic	Guidance
Cost	Klaviyo SMS costs about \$0.009–\$0.012 per US text
Where to use it	Where speed matters: abandoned checkout, back-in-stock alerts, shipping updates, time-limited peak offers
Campaign volume	A few SMS campaigns per month
Compliance	US marketing texts need written consent, and quiet hours must be respected

10.5 Example: rebuilding email for a \$6M pet brand

Illustrative example, not a real brand.

Before Lhotse

Area	Starting position
Welcome	A single email with 10% off
Checkout abandonment	15% offered in every single email
Missing sequences	No reorder, browse, or win-back sequences
Campaigns	Four full-list campaigns per week to 70,000 subscribers
Result	Email is 11% of website revenue

Lhotse's first 90 days

Weeks	Actions
1–2	Rebuild targeting based on clicks and orders. Move 24,000 inactive subscribers to a sunset flow.
2–4	Build a five-email welcome sequence (pet quiz, founder story, reviews, vet-backed education, then the offer). Limit the checkout discount to the last email, for first-time buyers only.
4–8	Add reorder reminders for the three best-selling food products (45-day reorder cycle, first reminder at day 38, with a subscribe-and-save offer). Add browse abandonment.
8–12	Add a 90-day win-back, a "gotcha day" (adoption anniversary) sequence using quiz data, and 10% holdout control groups on the welcome and reorder sequences.

How we measure it

- Email's share of revenue
- Holdout test lift vs. our fees
- Discount cost per order
- Klaviyo subscription tier after removing inactive subscribers

In a food-led pet brand, we would expect the reorder reminder to become the top revenue sequence within one or two reorder cycles. Proving it with a holdout test is what turns a trial quarter into a long retainer.

11. Keeping the Email List Clean

Summary: Klaviyo charges based on the number of active subscribers in the list. Inactive subscribers and fake sign-ups from bots cost a brand twice: once on the Klaviyo bill, and again because sending to them hurts inbox delivery. Engagement tiers, a sunset sequence, careful removal of dead subscribers, and bot protection answer the most common complaint from brand owners: a rising Klaviyo bill with flat email revenue.

11.1 How Klaviyo charges

Since February 2025, Klaviyo charges based on every "active" profile (subscriber). It automatically moves the account to the next pricing tier when the limit is exceeded.

Removed (suppressed) subscribers leave the bill. However, they can no longer receive any emails or enter any sequences, so removing someone is a marketing decision, not just a billing one.

Active subscribers	Monthly cost
1,000	\$30
5,000	\$100
10,000	\$150
25,000	\$400
50,000	\$700
250,000	\$2,300

Check Klaviyo's current prices before quoting any numbers to a client. A brand with 25,000 to 100,000 subscribers probably pays \$400 to \$1,400+ per month for email alone (our estimate).

A typical unmanaged list of 60,000 active subscribers

Segment	Last activity	Subscribers	Share of list	Effect on the brand
Engaged	Within 30 days	12,000	20%	Earns almost all revenue
Warm	31–90 days	9,000	15%	
Cool	91–180 days	6,000	10%	
Inactive	180+ days	30,000	50%	Costs money, hurts delivery
Bots / fake addresses	Not applicable	3,000	5%	Costs money, causes bounces

One brand owner publicly described this exact situation: paying for 50,000+ subscribers while only about 15,000 engaged with anything, with flat revenue and a rising bill.

Removing the inactive and bot segments would bring this list to about 27,000 real subscribers. That cuts the email bill by roughly \$300 per month, and all remaining emails go to people who actually respond.

11.2 How to categorize subscribers

Categories are based on clicks, website visits, and orders, **not opens**.

Category	Definition	How we treat them
Engaged	Clicked, visited, or ordered in the last 30 days, or signed up in the last 30 days	Every campaign
Warm	Same actions, 31–90 days ago	1–2 campaigns per week
Cool	Same actions, 91–180 days ago	Strongest monthly send; targeted win-back

Category	Definition	How we treat them
Inactive	Nothing in 180+ days	Sunset sequence, then remove
Protected	Ordered in last 12 months, active subscriber, VIP, or has an open order or support ticket	Never remove automatically; keep in post-purchase and transactional emails

Who to remove (suppress)

- Hard bounces and spam complaints (Klaviyo does this automatically)
- People who did not re-engage after the sunset sequence
- Confirmed bots
- Disposable email addresses and malformed addresses
- People who received 3+ emails in 180 days with no click, website visit, or order

11.3 Sunset sequence process

Step	Stage	What happens
1	Entry trigger	No click, visit, or order in 180 days AND no order in 12 months. Use 270 days for products with long buying cycles.
2	Re-permission	1–2 emails over 7–10 days, with a one-click "yes, keep me subscribed" button
3	If they click	Move them back to the warm category
4	If they do not click	Remove them with a reason tag (e.g., "sunset_2026Q4") so the removal can be tracked and undone if needed
5	Keep it running	Run it as an ongoing automated sequence, not as an annual one-time purge
6	Report	How many were removed, how category sizes changed, and how click and order rates changed

One manufacturer who removed unengaged subscribers and added a sunset flow publicly reported their open rate rising from 45% to 55% up to 65% to 70%. Opens are not a great metric (Section 9), but the direction confirms the point: emailing fewer, more engaged people improves every other metric.

11.4 Bots and list bombing

List bombing happens when bots flood a sign-up form with real or fake email addresses. The brand then pays to store junk contacts, and its welcome emails bounce or land in spam.

Warning signs

- Sign-up spikes at odd hours or all from one country
- Random-string names or website URLs in the name field
- High bounce rates on the very first welcome email
- Clusters of unusual email domains

How to protect sign-up forms

Protection	What it does
CAPTCHA or bot protection	Added to every form
Honeypot field	A hidden field that only bots fill in (real people never see it)

Protection	What it does
Double opt-in	Used for high-risk sign-up sources: footer forms, countries the brand does not ship to, API sign-ups
Disposable domain blocking	Blocks common disposable email domains
Sign-up alert	Triggers when daily sign-ups reach 3 times the usual daily average
Cohort removal	Removes any subscriber cohort affected by a bot attack

This matches Klaviyo's own guidance.

Never buy an email list. Purchased lists contain spam traps and dead addresses. One documented case bounced 12% on its very first send.

12. Email Security Settings Explained Simply

Summary: Gmail, Yahoo, and Microsoft now require three email security settings (SPF, DKIM, and DMARC) from brands sending bulk email, and they reject email from bulk senders that do not meet these rules. Starting with a DMARC record that only monitors, without blocking anything, meets all current requirements, while moving to blocking mode step by step is best practice. **A missing DMARC record, or having two of them, is the most common and most actionable finding we make in a free audit.**

12.1 How the three settings work together

Setting	Plain-English meaning	What it does
SPF	The list of computers allowed to send email for the domain	Checks whether the sending computer is authorized
DKIM	A digital signature that proves the email is really from the brand	Signs the email with a private key; the signature survives when the email is forwarded
DMARC	The rule that ties SPF and DKIM together	Links both checks back to the visible "From" address and tells providers what to do with failures: monitor, send to spam, or block entirely

When an email arrives, the email provider looks at three header lines:

```
From: hello@brand.com
Return-Path: bounces@send.brand.com
DKIM-Signature: d=send.brand.com
```

Header line	What it is	Check that uses it	Question the check asks
From:	The visible sender the customer sees	DMARC	Did SPF or DKIM pass AND match this domain?
Return-Path:	The technical sender	SPF	Is this computer allowed to send for this domain?
DKIM-Signature: d=	The domain that signed the email	DKIM	Does the digital signature match the public key in DNS?

Alignment: `send.brand.com` and `brand.com` share an organizational domain, so they count as aligned.

12.2 SPF: who is allowed to send email for this domain

An SPF record is a text record in the domain's DNS (the phone book of the internet). It lists every tool allowed to send email as that brand.

Example:

```
brand.com. IN TXT "v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com include:mail.helpdesk-vendor.example ~all"
```

Part of the record	What it means
<code>brand.com. IN TXT</code>	A text record published on the brand's domain
<code>v=spf1</code>	Version (marks this as an SPF record)
<code>include:_spf.google.com</code>	Allows Google Workspace to send
<code>include:mail.helpdesk-vendor.example</code>	Allows a helpdesk tool to send as @brand.com
<code>~all</code>	Soft-fail everything else

SPF rules

Rule	What goes wrong if broken
Only one SPF record per domain. Having two makes SPF completely invalid.	SPF fails for everyone
Maximum 10 DNS lookups. Each <code>include:</code> , <code>a</code> , <code>mx</code> , etc. counts as one, including lookups inside lookups.	Permanent error, usually when an 11th tool is added
SPF checks the technical sender , not what the customer sees in "From:"	SPF can pass while the DMARC check still fails
SPF breaks when emails are forwarded	This is why DKIM is more reliable

SPF qualifiers (the ending of the record)

Qualifier	Meaning	Use
<code>~all</code>	Soft fail	Normal
<code>-all</code>	Hard fail	Strict
<code>+all</code>	Authorizes everyone	Never use: anyone in the world can send as the brand

Klaviyo's sending domain lives on a subdomain (like `send.brand.com`) and handles its own SPF and DKIM. Do not add Klaviyo to the main SPF record unless Klaviyo's setup screen asks for it. Shopify handles its own SPF for Shopify-sent emails.

12.3 DKIM: proving the email is really from you

DKIM adds a digital signature to every email. The signature header says which domain signed it (`d=`) and which key to use (`s=`). The public key lives in DNS and can be checked by anyone.

Standard	Requirement
Key length	2048-bit recommended; 1024-bit minimum
Alignment	The signing domain must be the From domain or a subdomain of it
Coverage	EVERY tool that sends as <code>@brand.com</code> needs a DKIM signature: email service (Google/Microsoft), Klaviyo, help desk, review app, subscriptions
Rotation	Keys managed through Klaviyo rotate automatically. Rotate self-managed keys at least yearly, keeping the old key live for 7+ days.

12.4 DMARC: tying it all together and setting a policy

A basic starting DMARC record at `_dmarc.brand.com`:

```
v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc-reports@brand.com; adkim=r; aspf=r
```

Setting	What it means	Starting recommendation
<code>v=DMARC1</code>	Marks this as a DMARC record	Always first
<code>p=none</code>	Monitor only; take no action on failing emails	Start here
<code>p=quarantine</code>	Send failing emails to spam	Step 3
<code>p=reject</code>	Block failing emails entirely	Step 4
<code>rua=</code>	Where to send reports	Always set this
<code>adkim=r</code>	Relaxed DKIM matching (subdomains count)	Use relaxed

Setting	What it means	Starting recommendation
<code>aspf=r</code>	Relaxed SPF matching (subdomains count)	Use relaxed
<code>t=y</code>	Testing flag (new in the 2026 standard)	Use while testing quarantine

The 2026 DMARC standard removed ``pct`` (percentage). Do not raise a missing `pct=100` as a finding, because it is not one. Bringing it up with a technical buyer tells them we are out of date.

The four-step path to full protection

Step	DMARC record	How long	When to move on
0. Publish	<code>p=none</code> + reports address	Day 0	Reports are arriving
1. Discover	<code>p=none</code>	2–4 weeks	Every tool sending email is identified
2. Align	<code>p=none</code>	2–6 weeks	Every legitimate tool passes aligned SPF or DKIM; 98%+ passing for 2 weeks in a row
3. Quarantine	<code>p=quarantine</code> (optionally add <code>t=y</code> first)	2–4 weeks	No legitimate failures; no reports of missing mail
4. Block	<code>p=reject</code>	Ongoing	Weekly review of reports; every new tool added goes through a change request

Who sends email as @brand.com on a Shopify brand

Type of tool	Examples
Company email	Google Workspace or Microsoft 365
Marketing	Klaviyo, Shopify Email
Store	Shopify notifications
Customer service	The help desk tool
Subscriptions	ReCharge
Customer programs	The reviews app, the loyalty app
Back office	Invoicing tools, HR tools, warehouse notifications

The tools that break full blocking are always the ones nobody remembers exist.

Why Shopify brands specifically are at risk

Shopify rewrites the sender address to shopifyemail.com when a brand has either *no* DMARC record *or two of them*. This is visible from outside and is a clean, easy-to-demonstrate finding for our free audit.

12.5 What email providers now require

Requirement	Gmail	Yahoo / AOL	Microsoft
Minimum volume for bulk rules to apply	About 5,000+ emails/day to Gmail addresses; permanent once reached	Bulk senders (no published number)	5,000+/day
SPF + DKIM	Required	Required	Required
DMARC	Required; monitoring-only (<code>p=none</code>) is enough	Required	At least monitoring-only
One-click unsubscribe button	Required for marketing emails	Required; honor within 2 days	Expected
Spam rate	Below 0.1%; never above 0.3%	Below 0.3%	Low complaints expected

Requirement	Gmail	Yahoo / AOL	Microsoft
Enforcement	Rejects some failing emails (since November 2025). Above 0.3% spam rate, Gmail stops helping until the rate is below 0.3% for 7 straight days.	Rejects or filters	Rejects with specific error code (since May 2025)

Every brand we target qualifies as a bulk sender. Gmail holds 54.4% of US inboxes, so one campaign to about 9,200 US subscribers probably crosses Gmail's bulk threshold.

Rejected email shows up as bounces in Klaviyo, not in a test inbox screenshot. Always read the bounce reason codes.

12.6 Klaviyo's sending setup

New Klaviyo accounts start on a shared sending domain with shared reputation. Gmail shows these emails as "via klaviyomail.com", meaning the email looks like it came from a Klaviyo computer, not the brand's own domain. Klaviyo requires bulk senders to set up a branded sending domain.

Klaviyo's own warning thresholds are stricter than Gmail's:

Metric	Klaviyo warning threshold	Gmail limit
Spam complaint rate	Above 0.05%	0.1%
Bounce rate	Above 2%	No equivalent listed

Blocks on Klaviyo's shared sending pool are Klaviyo's problem to fix. Every Ascent contract must say this clearly so there are no misunderstandings.

12.7 What is NOT a real finding

Do not use these as a reason to pitch Ascent. They are not real problems.

False finding	Why it is not a problem
"DMARC is only p=none"	Monitoring-only DMARC satisfies all three major providers
"You're missing pct=100"	That tag was removed from the DMARC standard in 2026
"No BIMI is hurting delivery"	BIMI adds a logo in Gmail; it has zero effect on whether emails reach the inbox
"Promotions tab = deliverability problem"	Gmail treats the Promotions tab as part of the inbox
"One seed test shows spam, so you're blocked"	Seed test accounts have no email history, so providers treat them differently

Lead with real findings instead:

- No DMARC record at all
- Two DMARC records
- Failed alignment
- Shared Klaviyo domain on a big list
- Shopify sender rewrite
- SPF over its lookup limit
- Missing one-click unsubscribe
- Order confirmation emails landing in spam

12.8 Ascent repair process: no disruption to sending

Day	Work	Actions	Safety guardrail
0	Access and baseline	Read-only Klaviyo access; DNS contact info; Google Postmaster Tools setup; DMARC report inbox; record current metrics	No DNS changes yet
1–3	Inventory and quick wins	List every tool sending email; fix SPF to under 10 lookups; remove duplicate records; publish DMARC monitoring-only if missing	Add records before removing any; one change at a time
3–5	Alignment	Set up branded Klaviyo sending domain; add DKIM for Google, help desk, reviews, subscriptions; verify one-click unsubscribe	Old sending path stays live until new one is verified
5–10	List cleanup	Remove bounces, bots, and inactive profiles; build engagement tiers; launch sunset sequence; add bot protection to forms	Removals are tagged and reversible
10–14	Warm-up and repair	Start the warm-up schedule (Section 13); fix Microsoft-specific problems first in UK/Canada/Australia; write handover document	Automated sequences keep sending throughout
Weeks 3–12	Monitor and enforce	Weekly metrics check; move DMARC toward blocking as reports confirm it is safe; 30-day review; Lhotse proposal if the brand fits	Rollback plan for every DNS change

For large enterprise clients (A3): they usually want their own IT team to make DNS changes. For each step, give them a change request document that lists:

- The exact records to add
- Why each one is needed
- How to verify it
- How to undo it if needed

13. How to Test Whether Emails Actually Reach the Inbox

Summary: A "seed test" (sending a test email to a panel of fake test accounts) shows how an email provider treats a stranger with no history, while Google Postmaster Tools shows how the provider actually treats the brand's real customers. Sender reputation is protected by only emailing people who engaged recently, measured with real data, and dedicated sending IP addresses are only for very large, consistent senders. The industry average inbox rate is already above 80%, so "80% inbox rate" is too weak a success bar for Ascent. We use a full scorecard instead.

13.1 Where emails end up (industry data)

According to Validity's 2025 benchmark report, 83.5% of marketing emails reached the inbox, so about 1 in 6 missed. Spam placement rose from 4.5% in Q1 to 8.6% in Q4.

Country	Gmail share (inbox rate)	Microsoft share (inbox rate)	Yahoo share (inbox rate)	Overall inbox rate
United States	54.4% (88.8%)	10.8% (75.8%)	21.8% (86.4%)	85.0%
Canada	45.5% (94.4%)	27.9% (78.9%)	12.2% (88.6%)	86.7%
United Kingdom	41.1% (91.8%)	32.3% (86.9%)	7.8% (90.2%)	87.8%
Australia	47.3% (92.6%)	30.2% (77.7%)	7.5% (86.4%)	85.0%

Source: Validity. "Share" is the provider's share of inboxes in that country. No data for Ireland or New Zealand.

Microsoft is the weak spot outside the US. It holds about a third of inboxes in Canada, the UK, and Australia. Brands have reported months of emails going to Hotmail's spam folder even when they were only emailing 30-day-engaged subscribers, so for non-US brands we check Microsoft first.

Gmail's "Promotions" tab is not spam. Klaviyo calls it "a type of inbox," and no sender can choose which tab a message lands in. Since September 2025, Gmail has sorted the Promotions tab by relevance, so low-engagement senders sink within it.

The honest pitch is about staying visible inside Promotions. That is an engagement argument, not a claim to "get you out of Promotions."

13.2 The measurement toolkit

Tool	What it shows	Limitations
Google Postmaster Tools	Gmail spam rate, compliance status	Needs enough daily Gmail volume to show data
Yahoo Sender Hub	Yahoo sender data and complaints	Yahoo only
Microsoft SNDS	Outlook-level data by IP address	Only useful with a dedicated sending IP
Klaviyo reports	Bounces, complaints, engagement by provider	Opens distorted by Apple auto-opens
DMARC aggregate reports	Every source sending as the brand's domain	Needs a report processing tool at larger volumes
Seed tests	Where a test email lands across a panel of fake accounts	No engagement history; panel mix skews the score

13.3 How to use seed tests correctly

Seed test accounts do not behave like real people, because email providers treat new accounts differently. The mix of accounts in the panel also moves the score.

Seed accounts at	Typical inbox placement
Microsoft and Apple	Around 75% to 76%
Gmail and Yahoo	86% to 87%

The right way to use a seed test:

- Weight the panel to match the brand's actual mix of subscribers (how many Gmail, how many Microsoft, etc.)
- Read the results as a trend across several sends, not a one-time score
- Always pair seed test results with Google Postmaster spam rate data, bounce reasons, and DMARC data

The real warning signs are spam placement at multiple providers at the same time, or order confirmation emails landing in spam.

The Ascent Health Scorecard

This scorecard replaces the simple "80% inbox rate" pass bar.

Metric	Target at 30 days	Where to check
DMARC pass rate on real emails	98%+	DMARC reports
Gmail spam rate	Below 0.1% (aim for below 0.05%)	Google Postmaster Tools
Bounce rate	Below 1%	Klaviyo
Microsoft inbox rate	Measurably better than before Ascent	Weighted seed test trend + provider engagement data
Order confirmation emails	Landing in inbox at all major providers	Seed tests and real order tests
One-click unsubscribe	Present on all marketing emails	Check email headers
Revenue per email sent	Flat or better vs. the same weeks last year	Klaviyo

13.4 Shared IP vs. dedicated sending IP

Factor	Shared IP (Klaviyo default)	Dedicated IP
Reputation	Shared with other Klaviyo senders	The brand's alone
Volume required	None	High and consistent; gaps in sending let it go cold
Cost	Included in Klaviyo	Extra fee plus warm-up effort
Main risk	If another brand on the same pool gets blocked, the brand might be affected	Every mistake is purely the brand's own problem
Best for	Almost every brand we target	A3 brands with large, consistent daily sending volume

At Gmail, **domain reputation** now carries most of the weight, not the IP address. For almost every brand we target, authenticated email and an engaged list matter far more than having its own IP address.

Shared sending pools do fail. One merchant reported Gmail blocking Klaviyo's shared IPs, bouncing 22.5% and 60% of two Black Friday 2025 campaigns. Even then, the fix was escalating to Klaviyo and tightening targeting, not switching to a dedicated IP.

13.5 Warm-up schedule for a new sending domain

A brand that needs a new branded sending domain (e.g., moving from "via klaviyomail.com" to sending from "send.brand.com") must warm it up gradually. This schedule is based on Klaviyo's own guidance. Third-party "warm-up" services have no role here.

Weeks	Who gets campaign emails	Automated sequences
-------	--------------------------	---------------------

Only step up if spam complaints stay below 0.05% and bounces below 1%. Otherwise, hold the current level for another week.

Important timing

Peak season	Black Friday date	Start warm-up by
2026	November 27, 2026	About September 18, 2026 (window has passed)
2027	November 26, 2027	About September 17, 2027

Brands that missed the window should stay on their current authenticated path through peak season and migrate in January.

13.6 How to handle delivery problems (incident runbook)

Problem	How you notice it	Severity	First 24 hours	Recovery
Gmail spam rate above 0.3%	Google Postmaster Tools	Critical	Only send campaigns to 30-day-engaged subscribers; review recent list sources	7 clean days, then ramp back up tier by tier
Bounce rate above 2%	Klaviyo	High	Read the bounce error codes; pause new sign-up sources; check forms for bots	Remove the affected cohort; re-verify sources
Microsoft rejections	Bounce reason codes	High	Check SPF, DKIM, DMARC, and alignment on that sending path	Fix, then retest
Shared IP blocked	Bounce error codes; Klaviyo notification	Medium to high	Open Klaviyo support ticket; narrow sends to engaged-only	Klaviyo moves traffic; record this in the client report
List bombing (bot sign-ups)	Sign-up spike	Medium	Add CAPTCHA and double opt-in to affected forms	Remove the affected cohort
DMARC failures after adding a new tool	DMARC aggregate reports	Medium	Add DKIM or SPF for the new tool	Add a change-request step for future tool additions
Volume jump before peak	Sending plan	Preventive	Ramp up over 4–6 weeks	Follow the peak SOP (Section 14)

13.7 Validity's "Heatwave" blocklist

Item	Detail
Announced	September 3, 2026, by Validity
What it targets	Domains that use fake warm-up networks (networks of fake accounts that artificially exchange emails, opens, and replies to build a reputation)
Size at launch	More than a million domains listed
Partners	Proofpoint, Spamhaus, SURBL, Comcast, and beehiiv
Use by Gmail or Outlook	Unconfirmed

Email specialists have separately noted that filtering of cold emails has increased.

Audience	Action
Clients	Klaviyo's own warm-up process is the right method. No one should use warm-up networks.

Audience	Action
GrowMailers	Stop all fake warm-up activity on GrowMailers' own outreach domains immediately. A deliverability agency whose own domain is on a blocklist has zero credibility.

14. The Shopping Holiday Calendar

Summary: Black Friday falls on November 27, 2026 in all six of our target markets, which is 60 days from the date of this document. The planning year runs from the early-October setup freeze to the following September, and market-specific events such as Boxing Day, Mothering Sunday and Australia's End of Financial Year shape both client calendars and GrowMailers' selling windows. In 2025, US peak grew while the UK, Canada and New Zealand were flat or down. Outside the US, peak revenue is therefore about taking share, not riding overall growth.

14.1 Key dates: October 2026 to November 2027

Date	Event	Markets	Why it matters
Oct 6–7, 2026	Amazon Prime Big Deal Days	All except NZ	Counter with bundles and loyalty perks, not deeper discounts
Oct 12, 2026	Thanksgiving	Canada	Food and drink, gifting
Oct 31, 2026	Halloween	US, Canada, UK, Ireland	Candy; pet costumes
Nov 1, 2026	UK Black Friday campaigns begin (Black Friday week is Nov 23–30)	UK	Month-long UK peak
Nov 11, 2026	Singles Day	All	Beauty, especially in Australia and NZ
Nov 26, 2026	Thanksgiving	US	Food and drink
Nov 27, 2026	Black Friday	All six	Biggest day for all four product types
Nov 30, 2026	Cyber Monday	All six	
Dec 1, 2026	Giving Tuesday	US	Cause-linked campaigns
Dec 14, 2026	Green Monday	US	Last reliable ground shipping date
Dec 19, 2026	Super Saturday	US, UK	Last-minute gifting; digital gift cards
Dec 26, 2026	Boxing Day	Canada, UK, Ireland, Australia, NZ	Major sale day outside the US
Jan 1, 2027	New Year	All six	Resolutions: supplements, health, food
Feb 6, 2027	Lunar New Year	All	Food gifting
Feb 14, 2027	Valentine's Day	All six	Beauty, food and drink
Mar 7, 2027	Mothering Sunday	UK, Ireland	Beauty and food gifting
Mar 17, 2027	St Patrick's Day	Ireland and diaspora	Food and drink
Mar 26–29, 2027	Easter	All six	Chocolate, gifting
May 9, 2027	Mother's Day	US, Canada, Australia, NZ	Beauty's biggest non-Q4 moment
June 2027	Australian End of Financial Year sales	Australia	A month-long sale period; budgets reset July 1
Jun 20, 2027	Father's Day	US, Canada, UK, Ireland	Grooming, food and drink
July 2027	Amazon Prime Day	All except NZ	Counter-program
Late Jul–Aug 2027	Back-to-school	US, Canada	Lunchbox food, routines, supplements
Sep 5, 2027	Father's Day	Australia, NZ	
Nov 26, 2027	Black Friday 2027	All six	

Calendar shift to flag with clients: Cyber Monday moves from December 1 (2025) to November 30 (2026). As a result, November 2026 will look stronger year-over-year and December 2026 will look weaker, purely because of the date change. Warn clients before they read too much into the comparison.

14.2 How big peak season was in 2025

Market	What was measured	2025 result
United States	Cyber Week online spending	\$44.2B (+7.7%)
United States	Cyber Monday alone	\$14.25B (+7.1%)
United States	November–December total	\$257.8B (+6.8%)
Global	Shopify merchants, Black Friday weekend	\$14.6B (+27%)
United Kingdom	Black Friday week online	–1.2%
Canada	Black Friday card payment volume	–4%
Ireland	Black Friday online card spending (2024 data)	€120M (+22%)
Australia	Black Friday weekend	Parcels up 6.3%; about A\$1.5B spent
New Zealand	Black Friday non-food spending	NZ\$55.6M (–6.2%)

Why peak concentration matters for Ascent

Fact	Implication
Cyber Week (5 days) generated 17.1% of the entire US November–December season	A few days carry a large share of the season
About 1 in 6 US brands takes 30%+ of yearly orders in Black Friday week	For these brands, a delivery failure that week damages the whole year
Beauty and activewear were the strongest 2025 peak categories in the US, UK and Australia	These categories have the most to lose from delivery problems at peak

Peak moments by product type

Product type	Biggest moments beyond Black Friday	Email program implication
Beauty	Valentine's Day, Mothering Sunday, Mother's Day, holiday gifting, Singles Day	Gift guides, gift-with-purchase, sets
Supplements	January resolutions (the supplements "Black Friday"), September back-to-routine	Education series; subscription offers
Food and drink	Thanksgiving, holiday hampers, Easter, Lunar New Year, summer BBQ	Shipping cut-offs; gifting; perishability
Pet	Holiday gifting; flea and tick season (spring/summer); adoption anniversaries	Seasonal health sequences; "gotcha day" automations

Regional notes

Market	Note	Action
UK	Black Friday runs all month	UK segments must be live by late October
UK, Ireland vs. US, Canada, Australia, NZ	Mothering Sunday (March 7) and Mother's Day (May 9) are two months apart	Multi-market brands need two separate campaign tracks
Outside the US	Boxing Day is a major sale day	Hold December list capacity for it
Australia and NZ	Summer falls over Christmas	Plan seasonal creative accordingly

14.3 Peak season email preparation checklist

Timing	What must be done
12 weeks out (about mid-Sep)	Security settings final; any new sending domain already warming
10 weeks out	List clean: sunset run done, bots removed, engagement tiers rebuilt
8 weeks out	Peak calendar drafted; offers agreed with finance (minimum margin per product)
6 weeks out	Volume ramp begins: +1 send per week to engaged and warm tiers
4 weeks out	Segments, email creative and sequences locked; SMS consent list verified
2 weeks out	Quality check: links, discount codes, one-click unsubscribe, mobile layout
Peak week	Email engaged subscribers first, then wider tiers; check spam and bounces daily
1 week after	Move new buyers out of sale campaigns and into post-purchase sequences
3 weeks after	Remove peak-only subscribers who never engaged; plan January win-back

The rule that prevents most peak problems: Never let send volume jump suddenly. A list that has been quiet for months and is then blasted on Black Friday will see some of that email land in spam. Brands that paused sending before peak have reported bounce spikes on their first sale email.

15. When to Pitch Which Service

Summary: Pitch Lhotse when budgets have just reset and there is time to build: January to February, and June to mid-September. From mid-October to year-end, sell only low-risk quick Ascent fixes and book January conversations. As of September 28, 2026, GrowMails has about three weeks of safe Ascent selling time left before the Black Friday setup freeze, and the next Lhotse window opens January 4, 2027.

15.1 The master selling calendar

Window	Dates	Lead offer	What Ascent can cover	Lhotse	Message
Pre-freeze sprint	Now to Oct 16, 2026	Ascent quick fixes	DMARC on current domain; alignment; list cleaning; bot removal; spam triage	Book January starts only	"Protect peak without changing your setup"
Freeze	Oct 16–Dec 31, 2026	None	Emergency repairs only	Sign for January	"Let's review your peak data in January"
Best window	Jan 4–end of Feb 2027	Lhotse	Full, including new sending domains	Full pitch	"New budget; here's what peak revealed"
Steady window	Mar–May 2027	Both	Full	US, Canada, non-gifting brands; Australia before EOFY	"Build the system before summer"
Second-best window	Jun–mid-Sep 2027	Both	Full; new domains warming by ~Sep 17	Aim for starts by early August	"Black Friday is won in summer"

Why this rhythm matters

Klaviyo's own checklist says Black Friday is won in summer, with setup, segments and automated sequences final by early October. Email agencies advise brands to hire email partners 8 to 12 weeks before Black Friday.

Most teams freeze changes in November, and getting set up takes 2 to 3 weeks. A retainer pitched in late October is nearly impossible to deliver well and very easy to lose.

Which service to pitch, based on today's date

Where today falls relative to Black Friday	Condition	What to pitch
More than 12 weeks before	Brand makes \$3M–\$20M in a target product type and LFS is 40 or higher	Ascent first, then Lhotse
More than 12 weeks before	Brand makes \$3M–\$20M in a target product type and LFS is below 40	Lhotse first
More than 12 weeks before	Brand is outside \$3M–\$20M (\$1M–\$3M or \$20M+)	Ascent only
6 to 12 weeks before	Any qualified brand	Ascent on current domain only; Lhotse proposals dated January
Within 6 weeks, or during the freeze	Any brand	No new projects ; emergency repairs; book January calls
January to February	Any qualified brand	Lhotse , with Ascent folded into onboarding if needed

15.2 Planning backward from Black Friday 2027

Month	Stage	Detail
June 2027	Pitch and discovery	First conversations and needs assessment
July 2027	Contract	Latest sensible signing date: early August
August 2027	Onboarding	Takes 2 to 3 weeks
September 2027	Build	Sequences rebuilt; new domain warming by about Sep 17
October 2027	Setup lock	Everything final by early October
Nov 26, 2027	Black Friday	Program runs on the finished setup

For a Lhotse client to be fully ready for peak, the latest sensible contract date is early August. After that, pitch a January start instead.

15.3 How long each deal typically takes

Service and client type	Typical time from first contact to signed	Implication
Ascent, founder decides	1–2 weeks	Can close within the pre-freeze sprint
Ascent, marketing lead + VP decides	2–3 weeks	Start by late September for October delivery
Ascent, enterprise with IT involved	3–6 weeks	Best sold in January or summer; expect a security review for DNS access
Lhotse, founder decides	2–4 weeks	Pitch in January, start in February
Lhotse, VP or Head of Growth decides	4–8 weeks	Start in early January for March starts
Lhotse, CMO + finance reviews	6–12 weeks	Start pitching in November or December for Q1 decisions

Planning estimates. Calibrate against GrowMailers' real closed deals.

How many accounts to audit each month

The formula is: accounts to audit per month = target clients ÷ (reply rate × meeting rate × close rate). The worked example below uses a target of 2 clients per month.

Step	Calculation	Result
Combined conversion rate	10% reply × 50% meeting × 25% close	0.0125
Audits needed per month	2 clients ÷ 0.0125	160 audits
Audits needed per week	160 ÷ 4	About 40
Researcher time	40 audits at 15–20 minutes each	About two researcher-days per week

Weekly rhythm

Day	Activity
Monday	Build and score about 50 prospect accounts
Tuesday–Wednesday	Run about 40 external audits and record 10–15 short videos
Thursday	Follow-ups, discovery calls and proposals
Friday	Pipeline review, re-scoring and a health check on GrowMailers' own outreach domains

15.4 Priority by market and time of year

Time of year	US	UK and Ireland	Canada	Australia and NZ
Jan–Feb	★★★★★	★★★★★ (non-gifting)	★★★★ (legal-compliant only)	★★★★
Mar–May	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★ (ready for EOFY by early May)
Jun–Aug	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★ (new budgets from July)
Sep–mid-Oct	★★ Ascent only	★★ (UK peak starts Nov 1)	★★	★★
Mid-Oct–Dec	Freeze	Freeze	Freeze	Freeze

16. Email Marketing Laws by Country

Summary: Cold email to businesses is easiest in the US, which runs an opt-out system (brands can email first, and recipients unsubscribe if they do not want it). It is more restricted in the UK (only companies registered with the government are fully safe) and tightly regulated in Canada and Ireland (where only specific published addresses work), while Australia and New Zealand use consent-based rules with some automatic exemptions for business addresses. Cold text messages are banned everywhere. In every country, GrowMailers must identify itself honestly, include a mailing address and a working way to unsubscribe, record where each contact came from, and never buy lists.

This section is research, not legal advice. Confirm each country's rules with a lawyer before scaling outreach there.

16.1 Rules that apply everywhere

#	Rule	What it requires
1	Be honest about who you are	A named GrowMailers sender, the real company name and accurate email headers
2	Honest subject lines	Subject matches the content; never use "Re:" or "Fwd:" in a first message
3	Mailing address and working unsubscribe	Both included in every commercial email
4	Fast, permanent opt-outs	Stored on one shared list used by every tool and team member
5	Record where the contact came from	The URL and date, plus a screenshot for Canada, Australia and NZ
6	No bought lists	Also no guessed or generated email addresses in strict countries
7	No cold text messages	Also no automated calls, AI voices or ringless voicemail, anywhere

16.2 United States: the basic rules

US federal law (CAN-SPAM) covers all commercial email, including business-to-business. It runs on an opt-out basis, so prior consent is not required. Every message still needs the following.

Requirement	What this means for GrowMailers outreach
Accurate email headers; honest subject line	The From, Reply-To and routing identify GrowMailers; the subject matches the email content
Identify the message as commercial	Say clearly that the message is about GrowMailers' services
Valid physical mailing address	A street address, a registered PO box or a registered virtual mailbox
Clear unsubscribe link, honored within 10 business days	Must work for at least 30 days after sending; no fee or login required; never sell or share opted-out addresses
GrowMailers is still responsible	Even if a third-party lead-gen vendor sends on our behalf
No harvesting addresses	Scraping addresses from sites that forbid it, or generating/guessing them, is a serious violation
Penalties	More than \$50,000 per non-compliant email

US rules for calls and texts (TCPA)

Topic	Rule
Auto-dialed or recorded/AI-voice calls and texts to mobiles	Require prior consent (texts count as calls under this law)
Marketing texts	Require <i>written</i> consent

Topic	Rule
National Do Not Call Registry	Protects residential and cell numbers
Business landlines	Generally exempt; but many founders use a cell phone as the business line, so scrub mobile numbers against the registry and call manually
Calling hours	8 AM to 9 PM in the recipient's local time zone
Fines	\$500 per violation, up to \$1,500 if intentional ; class action lawsuits are common

16.3 United Kingdom

Contact type or topic	Rule
Registered companies (Ltd, LLP, PLC, Scottish partnerships, government bodies)	May receive B2B marketing email without consent, as long as GrowMailers identifies itself and offers an easy unsubscribe
Sole traders and some partnerships	Need consent . Check the UK companies register (Companies House) first; if no company is registered, do not cold email
Named employee addresses (like jane@brand.co.uk)	Count as personal data. Needs a written justification, notice of the address source within one month (a first-email footer works), and any objection treated as permanent
A founder's personal Gmail address	Almost certainly counts as an individual and needs consent (our reading)
Calls	Screen against the Telephone Preference Service and Corporate TPS first; automated calls need consent
Penalties	Maximum fine since February 5, 2026 is £17.5 million or 4% of global revenue , whichever is higher

16.4 Canada: strictest rules in our markets

Canada's anti-spam law (CASL) applies to messages **sent into Canada from anywhere in the world**, including Nepal.

Topic	Rule
Basic requirements	Every commercial email needs consent (express or implied), sender identification and a working unsubscribe
Implied consent via a published address	ALL three must hold: the person published the address (e.g., on their company website); nothing near it says "do not send unsolicited messages"; the message is relevant to their business role
Regulator's warning	Implied consent is not a blanket license to email any address found online
Addresses that never qualify	Addresses found only through enrichment tools, and personal Gmail addresses
Referral exception	One message is allowed after a referral from someone who knows both parties; it must name the referrer in full
Required contents	Sender name, mailing address, and a phone, email or web contact valid for 60 days
Unsubscribe deadline	Within 10 business days
Proof of consent	The sender must be able to prove consent; keep a dated screenshot of where each address was publicly published

Topic	Rule
Penalties	Up to C\$10 million per violation for a business; recent cases against Indeed Canada, Hudson's Bay and DavidsTea all involved broken unsubscribe processes
Calls	Register with the National Do Not Call List (DNCL), keep an internal do-not-call list, identify yourself, and call only 9 AM–9:30 PM weekdays and 10 AM–6 PM weekends . The CRTC has fined foreign callers C\$175,000
Quebec	Marketing must be available in French; write in French or put Quebec lower in the outreach queue

16.5 Ireland, Australia, and New Zealand

Ireland

Topic	Rule
Registered companies	Email is allowed unless the company has objected
Named employee addresses	May count as a personal address needing consent; use generic company addresses (like info@brand.ie) until a lawyer confirms otherwise
Cold texts to mobiles	Need consent ; many Irish founders use a mobile as their business number
Penalties	Each unsolicited message is a separate offense
Enforcement	The Data Protection Commission closed 275 direct-marketing investigations in 2025, up 88%

Australia and New Zealand

Topic	Australia (Spam Act 2003)	New Zealand (Unsolicited Electronic Messages Act 2007)
Types of consent	Express or inferred	Express, inferred or deemed
Business address exemption	Inferred consent: address publicly displayed, message matches the person's business role, nothing nearby says "no unsolicited messages"	Deemed consent: publicly displayed business addresses, same rules as Australia's inferred consent
Required contents	Sender identification and an unsubscribe	Not stated in our research
Unsubscribe deadline	5 working days	5 working days
Penalties	Repeat violations up to A\$3.3 million per day	Not stated in our research
Calls	Check the Do Not Call Register before calling mobile numbers	Check before calling

Our research on Australia and NZ is not complete. Treat both as frameworks to confirm with a local lawyer.

16.6 Six-country comparison and pre-send checklist

Country	Cold email to businesses	Safest address type	Cold calls	Unsubscribe deadline	Risk level
United States	Allowed (opt-out system)	Named business address	Manual dial; scrub mobiles against Do Not Call	10 business days	Low (email) / High (calls and texts)
United Kingdom	OK for registered companies; sole traders need consent	Named address at a verified company, with a written justification	Screen against TPS and CTPS first	Promptly; any objection is permanent	Medium

Country	Cold email to businesses	Safest address type	Cold calls	Unsubscribe deadline	Risk level
Canada	Only published addresses meeting all three tests, or referrals	Published role address on their website	DNCL registration; strict calling hours	10 business days	High
Ireland	Registered companies yes; named staff unclear	Generic company address	No mobiles without consent	Promptly	High
Australia	Inferred consent via publicly published address	Published role address	Check Do Not Call Register	5 working days	Medium to high
New Zealand	Deemed consent via published address	Published role address	Check before calling	5 working days	Medium to high

Before sending any email, check all of these

- ☐ Real operating country confirmed (not just a registered-agent address)
- ☐ Address type allowed under that country's rules
- ☐ Source logged (URL, date; screenshot for Canada, Australia and NZ). UK: Companies House match and written justification on file.
- ☐ Not on the global unsubscribe list
- ☐ Named sender; honest subject line
- ☐ Footer includes GrowMailers' full name, mailing address, a statement that this is about GrowMailers' services, a data source note (for UK and EU) and a simple one-click unsubscribe
- ☐ Sequence of 3 to 4 messages over about 3 weeks, stopping at any reply

16.7 GrowMailers' own outreach setup

A deliverability agency's own outreach is its first case study. GrowMailers follows these rules.

Rule	Detail
Keep cold outreach on separate domains	Away from growmailers.com
Authenticate every outreach domain fully	SPF, DKIM and DMARC, moving toward blocking mode
Stop all fake warm-up immediately	See Section 13.7 on Heatwave blocklist risk
Keep volume low and human	Researched, personal emails at a steady per-mailbox pace
Monitor weekly	Check blocklists and Google Postmaster data; keep bounce rate below 2%

New Shopify owners are flooded with cold sales pitches. Online communities often label these pitches scams and specifically call out Gmail senders and "your store has a problem" subject lines.

What works is the opposite: a specific free fix shown in a short screen recording, with no pitch attached. Public "free audit" offers in forums almost never get a reply.

16.8 Rules our Lhotse clients must follow

Rule	Which country	What it means for Lhotse
Abandoned checkout is not consent	Canada	Only email Canadian cart abandoners with consent or an existing business relationship

Rule	Which country	What it means for Lhotse
Soft opt-in for past customers	UK	Past customers may get marketing for similar products, with an unsubscribe in every message
Unsubscribe within 2 days / 5 working days	Yahoo / Australia and NZ	Never delay processing unsubscribes
Written consent for marketing texts	US	Separate text message consent with clear disclosure; respect quiet hours
French-language marketing	Quebec	French sequences and campaigns for Quebec subscribers
Health and supplement claims	US, UK, Australia	Review every health claim in copy against FTC, ASA and TGA rules

17. How to Find Clients, Audit Their Setup, and Close the Sale

Summary: GrowMailers wins by showing real work, not just talking about it. The process is to build a precise prospect list, run a 15-minute audit from the outside (no login needed), send one specific free fix in a short personalized video, and then qualify the prospect using their own numbers. Every step in this section can be repeated by a researcher and will hold up in front of a technical buyer.

17.1 The full pipeline

The sales process runs through nine stages, from finding a store to onboarding it as a client.

Stage	Name	What happens	See
1	Source	Pull prospects from Store Leads	17.2
2	Gate	Apply the entry requirements	4.1
3	Score	Give each store a Lhotse Fit Score and an Ascent Urgency Score	3.3
4	Audit	Run the 15-minute external audit	17.3
5	Outreach	Send a short audit video and email	17.4 and 17.5
6	Discovery	Turn their numbers into a model	17.6
7	Proposal	Propose Ascent or Lhotse	17.7
8	Close	Get the agreement signed	17.7
9	Onboard	Start the 30-day plan and holdout tests	17.8

17.2 Step 1: Build the prospect list

Store Leads filter	What to set
Platform and country	Shopify or Shopify Plus; US, UK, Canada, Australia, Ireland, or NZ
Estimated monthly sales (Ascent)	\$83k+/month
Estimated monthly sales (Lhotse)	\$250k+/month for beauty and supplements; \$333k+/month for pet; \$417k+/month for food
Apps to include	Klaviyo
Apps to exclude	Printful, Printify, Fourthwall; DSers, Zendrop, AutoDS, CJdropshipping
Product categories	Beauty and fitness, health, food and drink, pet (clothing as secondary)
Post-filter checks	Registered-agent address trap (Section 5.5); marketplace-led; hired an email agency in the last 6 months

17.3 Step 2: The 15-minute outside audit (no login needed)

Boundaries: Use only publicly available DNS records and emails received as a regular subscriber. No login attempts, no scanning tools, no spoofing tests, and no contact with the brand's customers.

Part 1: Check the DNS records

Check	What it looks up	What to expect
1. SPF	The domain's SPF record	Exactly ONE record
2. DMARC	The <code>_dmarc</code> record	Exactly ONE <code>v=DMARC1</code> record

Check	What it looks up	What to expect
3. MX	The domain's mail records	Shows which email provider they use
4. Sending subdomain	The subdomain from the Return-Path in their email	Shows the sending setup
5. DKIM	The DKIM key named in their email's headers	A valid key is published

Run these commands in a terminal, replacing "brand.com" with the real domain:

```
DOMAIN=brand.com
dig +short TXT $DOMAIN | grep -i "v=spf1"           # 1. SPF: expect exactly ONE record
dig +short TXT _dmarc.$DOMAIN                     # 2. DMARC: expect exactly ONE v=DMARC1 record
dig +short MX $DOMAIN                             # 3. What email provider they use
dig +short TXT send.$DOMAIN                       # 4. Sending subdomain (from Return-Path in their email)
dig +short TXT <selector>._domainkey.<d-domain>    # 5. DKIM key (from their email's headers)
```

Count the SPF lookups manually or with a free online SPF checker. The limit is 10.

Part 2: Check the inbox experience

Subscribe with a Gmail and an Outlook test inbox, then check the following.

What to check	Where to look	What a problem looks like
Sender label	Gmail "From" line	"via klaviyomail.com", or sender rewritten to shopifyemail.com
Security settings	Gmail, then "Show original" message	SPF, DKIM, or DMARC showing "fail" instead of "pass"; From domain not matching
One-click unsubscribe	Email header: List-Unsubscribe-Post	Missing on marketing emails
Welcome email delivery	When it arrives and which folder	More than 1 hour late, or landing in Outlook junk
Sequence depth	Emails received over 14 days	Single welcome email; daily blasts to a subscriber who never clicked
Form protection	Sign-up popup on the site	No CAPTCHA; no double opt-in on risky sources
Browse and cart	Browse, then start checkout while logged in	No follow-up within 48 hours

Part 3: Rate and explain the findings

Finding	How serious	Which service	How to describe it simply
No DMARC, or two records	High	Ascent	"Your domain has no DMARC record, which Gmail and Yahoo now require from bulk senders. It's a two-minute DNS fix."
Shared Klaviyo domain on 5,000+ subscribers	High	Ascent	"Your emails say 'via klaviyomail.com,' meaning your reputation is pooled with other senders."
Shopify sender rewrite	High	Ascent	"Shopify is replacing your sender address with shopifyemail.com because of a security gap."
Landing in Outlook junk	High (UK, Canada, Australia)	Ascent	"Your welcome email landed in Outlook junk, and about a third of UK inboxes are Microsoft."
No one-click unsubscribe	Medium	Ascent	"Gmail requires a one-click unsubscribe."
SPF over the lookup limit	Medium	Ascent	"Your SPF record has too many lookups."
Only one welcome email	Medium	Lhotse	"Your welcome is one email, and there's no reorder reminder for a 30-day product."

Finding	How serious	Which service	How to describe it simply
Daily full-list blasts	Medium	Lhotse	"Sending daily to people who never click is what pushes a list into spam."

17.4 Step 3: Record a 90-second audit video

Time	Step	Example script
0:00–0:10	Hook	"Hi [name], I'm [your name] from GrowMailers. I joined the [Brand] list last week, and your [specific email] is genuinely good."
0:10–0:35	Show the finding on screen	"One thing stood out in the headers. [Show it.] This line means [finding]. In plain terms: [impact]."
0:35–0:55	Explain why it matters now	"With Black Friday on November 27 [or: Gmail's bulk-sender rules], this is the kind of thing that turns into bounces just as volume rises."
0:55–1:15	Give the free fix	"Here's the exact fix. [Show it.] Your developer can add it in minutes, and it's in the email below."
1:15–1:30	Soft close	"That's it. No pitch. If you want a second pair of eyes on the rest, just reply."

Record the real inbox or DNS output, never a generic slide. Keep the video under two minutes.

17.5 Step 4: Email templates

Each template below is sent with the audit video. Replace every item in square brackets before sending.

Template A: Ascent, to a founder (\$1M to \$5M brand)

Subject: [Brand]'s DMARC record

Hi [first name], I joined the [Brand] list to study your welcome emails (the [detail] one is great) and noticed something in the headers: [plain-English finding]. Since last year, Gmail, Yahoo, and Microsoft have been rejecting bulk email that fails this check, so it's worth fixing before Black Friday volume picks up. It's a small fix, and I recorded 90 seconds showing exactly what to change: [video link]. No strings attached. If you'd like me to look at the rest, just reply.

[Your name], GrowMailers

GrowMailers · [mailing address] · A one-off business message about our email services. I found your address on [source]. Reply "no thanks" and I won't contact you again.

Template B: Lhotse, to a Head of Marketing or Head of Growth

Subject: reorder reminder at [Brand]

Hi [first name], I've been on the [Brand] list for two weeks. Your campaigns are sharp, but I didn't see a reorder reminder for [product], which is roughly a [N]-day product. At your size, a working reorder and post-purchase system usually needs just 1–3% of monthly orders to be incremental to pay for a full retention team, and we prove it with a holdout control group rather than platform estimates. Worth 20 minutes in January, once peak is behind you?

[Your name], GrowMailers · [compliant footer]

Template C: Ascent, to a CRM or Retention specialist at a large brand

Subject: DMARC enforcement at [Brand]

Hi [first name], I work with enterprise brands moving from monitoring-only DMARC to full enforcement without disrupting sending. Looking at [Brand]'s headers, there are [N] sending tools currently not passing aligned checks. That is the kind of thing that becomes an emergency the week of a big send. I've outlined the full inventory below and included a zero-downtime repair sequence. Happy to walk through it in 20 minutes if useful.

[Your name], GrowMailers · *[compliant footer]*

17.6 Step 5: Build a financial model on the discovery call

Discovery call questions

1. "What's your email's share of website revenue, and what attribution window does Klaviyo use?"
2. "How many total orders a month, and what's your average order value?"
3. "What percentage of buyers come back within 12 months?"
4. "What's your approximate gross margin?"
5. "What's your biggest email concern right now: delivery, revenue, or both?"

The breakeven model

Build the prospect's model live during the call using two formulas:

- **Repeat order contribution** = order value × gross margin – shipping
- **Lhotse breakeven** = monthly fee (\$3,000 to \$5,500) ÷ repeat order contribution. The result is the number of extra orders per month Lhotse needs to generate.

Step	Calculation	Result
Inputs	\$3,000/month fee; \$69 supplement; 70% margin; \$8 shipping	
Repeat order contribution	$\$69 \times 0.70 - \8	\$40.30
Breakeven	$\$3,000 \div \40.30	74 extra orders/month
Share of total orders	$74 \div 4,000 \text{ orders/month}$	1.9% needs to be incremental

When the prospect's own model shows that only 1% to 3% of orders need to be incremental, the price objection typically disappears.

17.7 Step 6: The Ascent proposal

The Ascent Statement of Work should include these eight parts.

#	Part	What it covers
1	Audit findings	What we found in their headers and inbox
2	Repair plan	Which settings we fix, in what order, and how long it takes
3	Safety guardrails	What we never touch; rollback plans for every DNS change
4	Delivery schedule	The 14-day repair timeline from Section 12.8, plus the warm-up schedule
5	Measurement	The Health Scorecard from Section 13.3
6	Shared Klaviyo pool notice	Blocks on Klaviyo's shared pool are Klaviyo's to fix, not ours
7	Lhotse pathway	30-day review; credit against the first month if they convert within 60 days
8	Price	\$5,000 flat. No retainer lock-in.

17.8 Step 7: Lhotse onboarding

Timing	Activities
Week 1	Read-only Klaviyo access; review flows, campaigns, segments, and list; current metrics snapshot; discovery call to confirm goals; 90-day plan drafted
Week 2	Segment rebuild (engaged, warm, cool, inactive) using clicks and orders, excluding Apple auto-opens; list review; suppress confirmed bots and hard-bounce profiles
Weeks 3–4	Rebuild the top-priority sequence (usually abandoned checkout, welcome, or reorder, whichever is the biggest gap); launch a 10% holdout control group
Weeks 5–8	Build the remaining sequences; migrate campaigns to engaged-only targeting; launch a sunset sequence for inactive subscribers
Month 3 onward	Weekly reporting; incremental test results; ongoing hygiene; move DMARC toward enforcement

Appendix A. Word List

Term	Plain meaning
AOV (Average Order Value)	The average amount a customer spends per order
Ascent	GrowMailers' one-time email repair service, priced at \$5,000
Attribution window	How far back Klaviyo looks when crediting a sale to an email (for example, "if they bought within 5 days of opening an email, we count it")
BIMI	A feature that shows a brand's logo next to its email in Gmail. It has no effect on inbox delivery.
Bounce	An email that could not be delivered. A "hard bounce" means the address doesn't exist. A "soft bounce" means a temporary problem.
CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost)	How much money it costs to get one new customer
CAN-SPAM	The US federal email marketing law. It runs on an opt-out basis.
CASL	Canada's email marketing law and the strictest in our markets
CPA (Cost Per Purchase)	Ad spend divided by all purchases, including returning customers
DKIM	A digital signature added to emails proving they really came from the brand's domain
DMARC	A security record that ties SPF and DKIM together and tells providers what to do when emails fail checks
DNS	The "phone book of the internet": a system that maps domain names to settings
DNVB	A brand that was born online and controls its products from design to delivery
DTC (Direct-to-Consumer)	A brand that sells directly to shoppers through its own website, not through a retailer
EOFY	End of Financial Year. In Australia this is June 30.
ESP (Email Service Provider)	The platform that sends the emails (for example Klaviyo or Mailchimp)
Flow / Sequence	An automated series of emails triggered by something a customer does (for example, adding to cart or buying for the first time)
GTM (Go-to-Market)	The plan for finding, pitching, and closing clients
Hard gate	A requirement that must be met before we will pursue a prospect
Holdout test	Holding back 10% of subscribers from an email and comparing their purchase rate with the 90% who got it, to prove the email caused purchases
ICP (Ideal Customer Profile)	A detailed description of the perfect type of client for a business
Klaviyo	The email and SMS platform our target brands use
Lhotse	GrowMailers' monthly email management retainer, priced at \$3,000–\$5,500/month
List bombing	When bots flood a sign-up form with fake or real email addresses
LTV (Lifetime Value)	The total amount of money a customer spends over their entire relationship with the brand
MER (Marketing Efficiency Ratio)	Total revenue divided by total marketing spend. It measures how efficiently marketing dollars turn into sales.
MPP (Apple Mail Privacy Protection)	Apple automatically "opens" emails when they arrive, which inflates open rate stats
PECR	UK rules for electronic marketing
Replenishment flow	An automated email reminder sent when a customer is likely about to run out of a product

Term	Plain meaning
Retainer	A monthly fee paid for ongoing services
SAM (Serviceable Addressable Market)	The portion of the total market that actually fits our criteria
Seed test	Sending a test email to a panel of fake accounts to see where it lands
Shopify Plus	Shopify's enterprise tier, costing about \$2,300–\$2,500/month
SMS	Text messages, used alongside email in retention programs
SOM (Serviceable Obtainable Market)	The realistic share of the market GrowMailers can actually win
SPF	A DNS record listing which computers are allowed to send email for a domain
Sunset sequence	A final series of emails asking inactive subscribers if they still want to hear from the brand, and removing them if they don't respond
TAM (Total Addressable Market)	The full size of the market if GrowMailers could capture 100% of it
TCPA	The US law governing calls and texts to mobile phones
Warm-up	Gradually increasing email volume on a new sending domain so email providers build trust with it

Appendix B. Sources

All data is from public sources current to September 2026 unless noted.

Source	What it was used for
US Census Bureau	Quarterly US e-commerce revenue
Store Leads	Shopify store counts, app data, and category mixes (September 18, 2026)
Klaviyo	Q2 2026 financial results; 2026 email benchmarks; sending setup documentation
Omnisend	2025 email marketing benchmarks
Validity	2025 inbox placement benchmarks (2024 data)
Validity Heatwave	Announcement of September 3, 2026
Triple Whale	DTC median order values and ad cost per purchase (US brands, 90 days to September 21, 2026)
ShipBob	2026 e-commerce survey
Meta	Q2 2026 earnings (ad pricing and impression data)
Glassdoor	US Email Marketing Manager salary data
FIGS, Hims & Hers, Temple & Webster	Public company financial filings
eMarketer	DTC share of US e-commerce
Litmus	Apple MPP open rate data (July 2026)
Flypost, Level CFO	Email and SMS share of DTC website revenue benchmarks
Adobe	2025 Cyber Week spending data
Shopify	Q3 2026 financial results
dmrcian	DMARC enforcement rates among top retail domains
Eightx	Team size data for online-first brands
Patrick Ta Beauty / Klaviyo	Black Friday 2024 case study

Where we used estimates or planning assumptions, we said so in the relevant section.